LITERARY PORTFOLIO / SELECTED WORK

LINDSAY MORRIS

FICTION · THEATER · PERFORMANCE

Selected short fiction and dramatic writing

Five short stories and one stage play

Richmond, Virginia · Lindzymorris@gmail.com

2026 / WRITING SAMPLES

01 / ABOUT THE WRITER

A little about me

I’m Lindsay Morris, a writer and performer based in Richmond, Virginia. My work spans short fiction, stage plays, sketch, and live storytelling, with a particular interest in complicated characters, uncomfortable situations, and the strange places where comedy and vulnerability overlap.

My writing has been published in Intrinsick Magazine and Santa Clara Review, and my work has been featured in New York, New Orleans, Chicago, and Richmond. I’m currently active at Coalition Theater in Richmond, following several years of writing, editing, and performing with theater companies in Chicago and New Orleans.

Publications & highlights

- Published fiction: Intrinsick Magazine and Santa Clara Review.
- Theater work presented at the Athenaeum Theatre and Green House Theater Center in Chicago.
- Original audio storytelling selected for Other World Theater’s Gateways series.
- Live storytelling, theatrical writing, and performance across four cities.

Education

Bachelor of Arts in English / Syracuse University / 2011

02 / SELECTED WRITING & PERFORMANCE CREDITS

Writing experience

Coalition Theater · Richmond, VA · 2025–present

Writer, Performer Writes and performs for live theater; active in the Richmond theater community.

Greenshirt Studios · Chicago, IL · 2018–2021

Writer Wrote the full-length script Semantics and the two-act play Crystal Highway.

Agency Theater Collective · Chicago, IL · 2018–2021

Writer, Editor Wrote and edited We Won't Fight, performed at the Athenaeum Theatre; edited Blonde Poison, performed at Green House Theater Center.

Barrens Theater Company · Chicago, IL · 2019–2020

Writer Wrote and edited 24-Hour Diner for a 24–48-hour play festival.

Other World Theater · Chicago, IL · 2019–2020

Writer Wrote Waiting, selected and recorded for the Gateways audio-story series.

No Shame Theater · Chicago, IL · 2017–2020

Writer, Performer Regularly performed personal stories and stand-up comedy, frequently exploring sex and relationships.

Ladylike Chicago · Chicago, IL · 2018–2020

Writer, Performer Wrote and performed What's My Number? for a women-run program addressing sexuality and gender.

Always Lounge Theater · New Orleans, LA · 2015–2017

Writer, Performer Wrote and performed short pieces with the company's lit-erotica group.

03 / SELECTED WORK

The writing

The following pages contain opening excerpts from each piece. A complete-works edition is included separately and also available as a combined portfolio.

01 Lucky Boy — SPECULATIVE FICTION

A dark, unsettling story about institutional power, enforced obedience, and the people caught inside it.

02 Cruella De Raven — DARK COMEDY

A theater performer must find a way home while trapped inside an elaborate, nearly inescapable costume.

03 Crumb-Struck — LITERARY SATIRE

A retail worker navigates corporate pressure, private humiliation, and an increasingly fragile sense of control.

04 Sushi, Please? — LITERARY FICTION

A mordantly funny, self-protective narrator confronts grief, addiction, and the limits of self-deception.

05 The Flying Nun — ABSURDIST COMEDY

A turbulent flight becomes a chaotic test of one deeply imperfect passenger's capacity for heroism.

06 We Won't Fight — STAGE PLAY

A woman attempts to orchestrate a peaceful family gathering, only to expose the conflicts she hopes to avoid.

CONTENT NOTE Some selections contain strong language, drug use, sexual content, and bodily or psychological distress.

01 / COMPLETE SHORT FICTION

Lucky Boy

SPECULATIVE THRILLER

Joey can't stop pissing himself. That squirming, red-haired motherfucker. When I complain, they give me the heavy chain, shackle me with double-knotted steel cinched tight at my waist. No stretching my legs over the Atlantic now.

I lay my elbows on the stripped plastic armrests and stare at the mini screen cracked into dozens of fresh spiderwebs. The plane has clearly been built for luxury, and despite the guards' best efforts, it still shows. Some amenities they'd gone out of their way to ruin, like the inflight movies, others they'd simply locked away. Half a dozen of us can't look away from a bottle of Don Julio sealed behind a glass case a few rows ahead.

When we left Fort Sumter, it was still dark. By the time we boarded in Charleston, the sun was coming up from the east. Hours later it was rising again. I swear we're flying in circles, pumping and dumping fuel all over the country, before touching down.

"They're trying to keep it hush-hush," Joey says.

"What?"

"I don't know."

"What don't you know?"

"Everything."

We both laugh. I look down at the dark stain drying between his legs and I feel bad for calling him out about the whole pissing-his-pants thing. I hadn't realized how young he was. No way this rugrat is built for whatever these bastards have in store.

As the hours stretch on, the guards stop bothering to check on us, occasionally tossing packs of crackers to shut up the worst of the complainers. I tear the plastic open and share a square.

"Thanks—"

Joey stalls, eyes flicking to the redacted lanyard shoved around my neck.

"It's Matterson," I say.

“Thanks, Mr. Matterson.”

I nod and do my best to get comfortable, ignoring the shifting metal on my groin. None of the seats recline. Someone shoved glue into the little switch by my side. I scratch at it with my nail for a while, trying to get the thing to give, but eventually I give up, cross my arms over my chest, and shut my eyes.

A few hours later I wake up shivering. It was hot when we took off, my pits slick and spicy from the humid Southern air. The guards on the plane are now dressed for much colder weather, outfitted in well-worn blue camo. Some have stripped off their thick fleeces and stretched out; others stayed fully dressed, even keeping their ski masks on.

Tap Tap Tap.

I turn my head and clock Joey smiling.

When he realizes I’m not going to ream him out, he goes back to tapping against the glass, stopping every few seconds to lift his head, looking for one of the guards before starting up again.

Behind me, someone picks it up. Tap Tap Tap.

“Knock it off,” a guard barks, not even looking up.

But then another prisoner joins in. Then another. Fingers on plastic. Nails on glass. The rhythm hopping rows, skipping seats, landing wherever it can. Tap Tap Tap.

“One a penny, two a penny,” I mumble.

Half the plane is in on it, tapping on armrests, trays, windows, knees, anything they can get their hands on, before one of the guards finally stands, kills the lights, and tells us to eat shit and die.

At least the lights are off.

Hours later when they unshackle us, I feel a flicker of relief, a brief burst of hope. Dumbass. The doors are open now and we’re lined up like good little inmates, freezing our asses off while we wait for our voluntary rehabilitation to begin. Snow comes down heavy, big freaking flakes swallowing the ground, making it impossible to get decent leverage as they march us forward, left, right, left, knee to chest, ass to groin, slipping and sliding through the worst of it. I already miss the warm shackles of the plane’s fuselage interior.

Joey is whimpering, cradling his right palm. A piece of skin froze to the metal walkway as we exited the plane and he had to rip it off to keep the line moving.

“My mom didn’t say it was gonna be cold,” he says miserably, a few stray tears already icing beneath his eyes.

I stick my tongue out, guiding it in little waves and divots as I attempt to catch a falling snowflake. A six-sided beauty lands on the tip of my glossa; it tastes like nothing.

Visibility is awful, but even still, it doesn’t take more than a second to look around and know we’ve fucked off to the absolute ass end of the United States, if we’re even still in the US. No laws, no justice. A perfect black hole caked in pretty white snow. I don’t have a clue where we are, but it doesn’t matter. North Dakota or Jupiter, either way, Lady Liberty, that green-eyed bitch wasn't looking.

Most of us do our best to hustle forward until the line comes into view. Other planes must have landed before us. Dozens of inmates stretch out as far as the eye can see, the line bending around a small wooden shack where a few guards stand clustered together, cigarette smoke misting above their heads, before looping back toward the building.

Past them, against the bone-white mountains, stands a hulking mass of cold steel and industry, its bottom half swallowed by rock and snow. Above it, an oblong metal cap bulges with a single long window wrapping around it like a visor. At its base is a fat gray door; in the distance, I can spot a series of red and green lights winking on and off as other inmates step off the line and dart inside.

“I gotta say, zero points for creativity.” The whole thing screams Secret Government Facility.

“Is that where they're gonna do it?” Joey asks, not taking his eyes off of the metal dome.

“Yep. That's where they’re gonna do it.”

Joey finally shuts up, wide eyes flicking up and down before shoving his injured hand into his jumpsuit, cradling it to his chest. We don’t speak for the next little while, inching along minute by minute, all of us shivering, eyeing the guards' cheap wool jackets and padded camo pants with frigid envy. Is there anything worse than bureaucracy in the face of the American death star?

The security guard to my right prowls back and forth, warning us to stay in line. He smokes Pall Malls at a healthy pace, giving us the stink eye after each used butt. It isn’t like anyone is stupid enough to run. We can hardly walk in this shit. If anything, I want to be “rehabilitated” faster if it means getting out of this cold. How quickly resistance dies in zero degree weather.

Behind me, one of the less ambitious delinquents is complaining; he griped nonstop on the flight over. I turn to look at the guy. He has close-cropped, freshly buzzed bleach blond hair. His eyebrows are thick black stumps connected by a few stubborn wisps down the middle.

“It’s not fair. I shouldn’t even be here!” he yells over the wind. He kicks at the snow, sending an icy spray back into his own face. “All I did was post a few memes. I wasn’t even the OP.”

“Did you tell them that?” Joey asks, perking up for the first time since we got off the plane.

“Yeah. But those phony cops wouldn’t hear it,” he says. “Since when are memes treason anyway?”

He looks at Joey. “You online a lot?”

Joey shakes his head.

“Figures. I’m kind of famous,” he says. “When we get back, look me up. ZinnWazRight69. I’m the original Milkshake Kid.”

We both shook our heads.

“Come on. You know the one.”

He makes a face, shoves a fist to his chin, arranges his mouth like he’s about to shit.

When we don’t say anything, he keeps going. “They said they already nailed some X user for it. But it was me. I’m telling you.”

He snorts. “There’s records and shit. No way they wipe me completely.”

Joey nods and the guy gives him a rough couple of knuckles to the head. They scuffle a bit, Joey losing his footing, going down twice in the snow before they both come away smiling. ZinnWazRight69 is a full-on jackass, insufferable in a way that would’ve made us friends if we’d met a dozen years ago.

I look around at the lot of us. All men. All assholes. And if you ask me, not one of them deserves whatever’s coming.

But no one asks me.

A few minutes later one of the guys drops down behind us. I see two men propping him up between them, slapping his cheeks, shouting into his face, trying to keep him moving. The line doesn’t stop.

The snow has soaked through our prison shoes, cold seeping up from the soles, numbing ankles, deadening toes. Every step feels heavier than the last. The cold isn't just on us anymore. It's inside us, burrowed deep until we're all shaking and shivering.

Joey starts coughing, choking on phlegm and snot, and ZinnWazRight69's got an arm around him, giving his back a few hard slaps. "Come on. Get it out."

"Hey," he calls out to one of the passing guards. "Can't you see the kid's freezing to death?"

The guard doesn't look back. Just keeps moving.

ZinnWazRight69 watches him go, jaw tight. He snorts, louder now. "Come on, man. I'm freezing my nuts off."

He grabs his whole package and sort of wangles himself around, gaining a little height in the process. Even in this temperature I catch the faint outline of flesh beneath his thin prison jumpsuit. A few of us laugh. Not because it's funny, but because it's better than not laughing.

"You know who I am?" he calls after the guard. "I'm the fucking Milkshake Kid." He grins.

"You hear me, you fascist fuck?"

The guard, a real thick son of a bitch, yanks him out of line.

"Finally, man," ZinnWazRight69 says, still smirking. "I've been waiting all day."

The guard throws an elbow into his face.

"Watch his mouth," another guard says, coming to help as they pull him toward the shack.

"Yeah. Watch my mouth."

He manages to yank a hand free, spreads a sloppy V with his fingers, sticks his tongue out and rolls it back and forth in fleshy waves.

The other guard gets in a punch to the kidney, and you can hear the breath rattle out of him as they drag him toward the shack, slamming the door shut behind him.

"He's gonna come back, isn't he?" Joey asks.

"Course he is." Not a shot.

Another guard wearing a ski mask and visor, bulging and faceless, comes by a minute later handing out juice boxes. He hands me a heavy brick, Pineapple Sunshine, the plastic frozen solid.

Bastard.

I grip it in my hands, flex it between my blue-tipped fingers before shoving it in my pocket.

Joey tries to get his open, but with only one working hand, he's struggling. His lip snags on the corner where he's trying to use his teeth and bright red blood blooms fresh on his lip.

My paternal instincts kick in because I grab his juice box instead, wrench the frozen corner loose, and press it into his hand. "Wipe your mouth," I tell him.

He does, then licks at the edge of the juice, getting a little Sunshine into him, his eyes going wide as the sugar hits. His tongue sticks on contact, the pink stretching as he pulls back. He goes in again, breathing hard on the surface to coax a little warmth before trying once more.

We're getting closer now, playing red light, green light. The snow is no longer big and fluffy; it's turned mean, frozen pellets buzzing past my ear. A constant heavy static rattling all around me.

"Looks like I'm almost up," I yell to Joey.

"Don't leave me," he says.

"You'll be fine. Just a few harmless cuts, a little snip-snip, and we'll be back on that plane before you know it." I try to mimic a pair of scissors but my fingers are too numb to make it look right.

I turn to go through but he clings to my arm. I grab his hand, give it a squeeze, then lift it off.

"Try not to piss yourself again, kid," I say, and rush through as soon as the door slides open.

My hands fly up on instinct, palms pressed hard over my eyes, my whole body convulsing in sharp, involuntary twitches as the heat of the room thaws me out like frostbitten chicken.

It takes a moment for me to get what's what, but eventually I get myself going. The room is bright, overly large, a mix of metal and blue tile set in dark gray grout covering the walls. The ceiling is gridded with long fluorescent panels sunk into white acoustic plates, muting a faint hum I can feel low in my gut.

"Jamie Matterson?" A middle-aged woman with a fat ass asks.

I nod. She gestures me forward, already moving behind her boat-like metal desk. I step up to the desk, my feet landing on a red X taped to the floor.

“Welcome to the Prosthetic Occlusion Compliance Clinic, Jamie," she says sweetly.

Reperfusion tears through my arms and legs, sharp needles bursting into cherry red flames as circulation staggers back. I shift my weight, hunting for a scrap of relief. My right leg bounces without permission, jittering up and down as the cold drains out of it.

“Please stand still while our computer finishes its scans.”

“And if I don’t?” I say. “If I tell you to go fuck yourself after keeping me out in the cold all night?”

The woman behind the desk smiles a little wider. “If you don’t do what you’re told, Jamie, I’ll have one of the guards come in, break your legs, and hold you up until I’m finished with you.”

I give her a little fuck you salute and stand still.

“No defects, abnormalities, or signs of cancerous rot,” she says. “Aren’t you the healthy boy.”

“You’re coming on a bit strong, aren't you?” I say, forcing a wink. “What time do you get off tonight?”

She ignores me and puts a fresh tablet on the desk.

“Sign here.” The tablet lights up, revealing bright white disclaimers in bold black lettering. There are hundreds of pages in the terms and conditions for me to read. I try to scan the first few paragraphs but after a minute I give up, scroll to the bottom, and sign.

I know a bullshit deal when I see one, but what are you gonna do? They had me dead to rights.

“Come on now,” I say. “I’m a great lay. Ask my ex, Kiko. She said the only thing wrong with me was my shitty personality. Not a word against my pecker, I swear.”

“We also need verbal consent. Please turn your head towards the camera,” she says icily, that pretty little smile turning sour.

“Which one?” I look around; the place is covered with them. Mounted in the corners of the ceiling, bolted onto scanning machines. Hell, there was even one dangling from the chest of fat ass right above her security clearance badge.

“Pick one,” she says, annoyed.

I choose tits.

“Do you agree to allow us to remove your molars, incisors, front teeth, back teeth, gum line, and jaw bone if necessary?”

I sort of wish I hadn't skipped those pages.

I nod, then remember myself. “Yes. Only if necessary? Right?”

“Next,” the woman calls, and I am already being corralled down a long, millennium gray hallway by one of the nameless camo boys. Now that the hour is actually upon me, I am no longer so keen on the deal after all.

My hand slips into my pocket and finds the juice box, still half frozen, slick with condensation. My fingers tighten around Pineapple Sunshine.

“Hey,” I say, turning just enough to catch the guard’s attention.

I bring the juice box down hard. The carton connects with the top of his skull. The sound is ugly and wet, like striking rain-soaked wood. He stumbles forward and I am grateful for the anonymity of the ski mask. I do not want to know his face.

I turn and run, barreling down the hall. Locked doors on all sides. I grab handles at random and I can smell my fear sweating through my jumpsuit. This was a really fucking dumb idea.

It occurs to me, too late, that the guard might have had keys. Or a security badge or a fucking phone.

I double back and find him no longer crumpled on the floor, but on his hands and knees, already pushing himself upright.

“You motherfucker,” he says, rubbing the top of his head.

I drop to the floor and reach for his pockets as he struggles to stand. It's awkward, all elbows and knees, the two of us tangled on the floor like idiots.

“I don’t have anything,” he snaps, shoving me off. “They don’t give us shit.”

We end up sitting there for a second, backs against the wall, knees up. He keeps rubbing his head and I keep breathing too fast.

“You got two choices,” he says finally. “Go where I tell you, or get us both in trouble and go right down the fucking mountain.”

“I’ll take the first one.”

He gets to his feet, hauls me up by the arm, walks ten feet, gut punches me, and shoves me through the nearest open door.

“Jesus,” I hear him mutter as it slams shut. “I hate this job.”

It doesn't look like any dentist’s office I’ve ever seen. I thought the equipment would be silver. I thought it would smell like fluoride and root beer. Goddamnit. I even let myself hope for those little lollipops they hand you after they floss your teeth.

Everything is wrong. From the uniformed grey walls to the chair with its thick metal restraints and the sour smell of ammonia permeating the air.

Fifteen minutes of freedom. Those first sweet steps of patriotic duty, and this is the reward.

It hardly seems fair.

But nothing has been fair in a long time. Not work. Not life, and certainly not the government.

I don’t even know what the hell came over me. One minute I’m rushing home to make dinner, trying to decide if it’s worth texting Kiko again or if I should just throw in the towel, and the next thing I know some Steely Dan motherfucker hands me a sign and I’m chanting with all the rest of them, fist high above me.

All around me were sweaty faces, sun-blotched skin, bony arms, pit-stained shirts. Bodies pressed close as we marched and sang, spitting out the furious taste of a system built against us. I was. We were. In sync.

I didn't even realize until we were half way down First Ave that I was marching for anybody other than myself. That maybe it wasn't just me that was sick of getting reamed out by my manager and her manager and all the managers before her.

It wasn't my fault someone hoisted me on their shoulders. It wasn't my fault that it felt so damn good. Fifteen minutes later a policeman had a boot on my neck and he didn't want to hear it wasn't my fault. I was arrested for the first time in my life. Never in my wildest fucking nightmares did I think it could happen to someone like me. What can I say? I thought I was immune. Exempt. Free and clear from any and all police brutality. They charged me with so many crimes it was separated by a second page break.

I have never felt such fear. Such cold, naked terror.

Then, beneath the words fifteen to life and Treason with a capital T, was the little check box that opted out of a trial in exchange for “experimental rehabilitation.”

It wasn't fair, and somehow it still surprised me I ever thought it would be.

I lie back in the chair. Why fight it?

The dentist comes in wearing a gray mask and matching scrubs. His eyes are bright blue. Cerulean, my mother would have said. She loved colors and hated politics.

She doesn’t know I’m here. Never even got the chance to break her heart. One phone call my ass.

“Do you guys ever think of choosing another color? All this metal on metal shit is really ahhhh.”

It hits my sinuses before I can process what happened, the spray, the mace, whatever the fuck it is the bastard just held up to my face, immediately gets absorbed by all those microscopic blood vessels in my mouth.

I gag a few times. I feel my whole body convulse, swallowing itself bit by bit until eventually I’m spit out again, a jellied wet mass.

“How about a little warning next time?” I sit up, wipe my face clumsily, my jaw already going numb.

“There won't be a next time, Jamie. Please lay down,” He pushes my head until it hits the headrest.

The lights dim. “Was that real, or was I just imagining it?”

He winks at me, then activates the restraints on the table. My arms become immobile. Not that I could move them anyway.

“Relax, Jamie.”

But I can’t relax. And I hate that he keeps using my name. We aren’t buddies, he isn’t someone I want with their fingers all up in my mucosa.

The doctor sticks something in my mouth. My tongue gets a taste of copper, bright fresh pennies dripping down my throat as my lips stretch wider and wider. He sticks a gloved finger inside me, tickling my uvula, and I can feel spittle beginning to flow down my chin.

“I want to goh fhomme,” I say. I can't help it.

The doctor nods but continues to work on my mouth.

“You’ve got a beautiful set of incisors.” I hear the clink clink as he taps them with professional admiration. Feel the vibration in my collarbone.

“Some of these boys who come in. No standards. Mouth full of cavities.”

He wrinkles his nose. “But every once in a while I get a beautiful set to work with. Just the other day I had a boy on my table with the most handsome molars. Broke my heart, ripping them out.”

He turns and uncovers a tray. I get a glimpse of dark titanium wires, thick copper filament, tiny Phillips-head screws. Nasty pieces of hardware laid out in rows. None of it gleaming. None of it new and none of it looks like it belongs anywhere near my mouth.

“You have no idea what a lucky boy you are,” he says, grabbing a pair of pliers off the tray. “This is far more humane than what we used to do.”

He shoves the pliers into the back of my mouth. I feel a sharp pressure, then an impossible pull, something tears. He sticks his hand back into my mouth and a moment later comes away satisfied, a nerve, dangling and wiggly like a worm, between his fingers.

“Lots of problems with those earlier iterations,” He continues, wiping his bloody glove on a towel beside him. “People trying to claw out their new implants. I imagine the pain was excruciating, not sure how some of them managed it. But don’t worry, we learned the hard way lithium batteries and flesh just don’t mix.”

There is a rapid escalation of sound, spinning metal grinding against teeth. I can feel the noise in my skull.

“Now for the fun part.”

I am terrified and I don't believe for a minute all the little lies the drugs are telling my nerve endings.

“Don’t worry. We’ll have you fixed up in a jiffy, minimal scarring. Nobody will notice a thing. And the best part? Your worst impulses, those nasty things you said or did to get yourself here, won’t ever be a problem again.

“Fwuk You!” bloody spit lands all over his grey scrubs. There is so much red everywhere.

“Merciful, really.” He says dabbing at his chest with the towel.

My eyes flicker back to the doctor’s baby blues.

He pulls a light down from above my head and I try to turn away, but it shines so bright I think I’ve gone blind, and without ever choosing it, the darkness carries me away.

#

I wake up in stages. My head is pounding and my ass aches from whatever shitty seat I’ve been shoved into.

My eyes open to a large sliver of daylight. I’m in a window seat, back on the plane. From what I can tell, Good Old America is staring back at me through the glass to my right. Whether it’s the same one I left, I couldn’t say.

All around me are wrapped faces. Bandaged jaws. Shirts soaked with drool, laps heavy with bloody cotton. I feel something wet and warm slide down the back of my neck.

My hand moves clumsily to my head and come away holding a lukewarm bag I assume was once filled with ice.

I reach up to touch my face and it feels numb. My fingers trace the swollen parts of my jaw.

“Fwhat dith theYhh do?” I ask the guy to the left of me.

His eyes seemed cloudy and panicked under a shock of distinctive copper eyebrows. All the more gruesome against a crown of white gauze.

“Jowey. Arw You Awhight?”

His jaw is moving bizarrely, opening and closing disjointedly, nothing but a waspy rattle coming out as the terror in his eyes grows.

“Okay, patriots. Listen up.” I crane my neck and lift up in my seat.

The guard at the front of the plane has his mask off. He looks early fifties. His army wannabe crew cut can’t disguise the balding at his temples. His posture is unnatural, a cheap imitation of a German shepherd held at attention.

“I said wake up.”

He kicks the back of a seat with his heavy black boots. The man in it lurches forward, still foggy.

“You’ve all been rehabilitated at the great expense of the United States of America.”

He claps once, then walks slowly down the aisle, his hand dragging over the gauze of a few shaved heads.

“Thanks to science, or engineering, or whatever the hell it was, Lady Liberty will be shining her satellite on you, twenty-four-seven. That means no more nasty words out of those mangled mouths of yours.” He stops and presses a finger to Joey’s forehead, right between the eyes.

“Fwakh Youhhaaaaaa,” I manage, trying to knock his hand away from him.

“Dont worry, son. You’re not alone anymore.” He stares at Joey. “Isn’t that right?”

“Nnohh.”

“What was that?” he says, smiling wider.

“Nnnoh wuhh stannn… alooonnn,” Joey slurs.

From behind him I hear someone else pick it up. “Nooh wuhh sthan alohn.”

More voices join in as it moves like a virus through the cabin, skipping rows, infecting bodies. Accents blurr, tempos falling in line. Getting louder and louder until it's all I can hear.

Joey grabs at my bindings. Pain shoots directly to my central nervous system as my own jaw slams open and closed without permission.

“No one sthandss alohn.”

“No one stands alohn.”

“NO ONE STANDS ALONE.”

Over and over, the words ooze past swollen gums and novocained tongues, each syllable stumbling out wet and thick, gaining strength in numbers as our voices become indistinguishable in the chorus of patriotism.

“NO ONE STANDS ALONE!” We are in sync. A single organism throbbing under one patriotic pulse.

To the left of me, Joey’s jaw moves faster, his teeth slamming into one another as he fights to control his movements. Enamel cracks against enamel, revealing the wet pulp underneath as

horror shines through his drug addled eyes. He shoves his fingers in his mouth, tugging and frothing as bits of bone and blood speckle my face.

I grab at his hands, trying to stop him, but he turns his panic on me. Joey grabs my throat. I can feel the dry, cracked edges of his fingernails pressing into the soft flesh of my Adam's apple.

A hot blast of foul, heavy rot from his ruined teeth nearly overwhelms me before I smash a fist along the side of his face, trying to get free. Pain shoots through my knuckles as they crunch against hard skull.

I watch as the whites of his eyes bloom red with the blow, then black, as every fragile vein bursts at once, flooding the sclera with thick, rust-colored fluid.

The chorus around us grows louder and louder until all I can hear is them, and all I can see is him.

The German shepherd raises his hands, trying to quiet us, but our voices roll over him, louder and louder. He grabs the collar of some poor asshole and slaps twice, trying to make him stop chanting. It doesn't do a damn thing. His face reddens as he shouts for backup, and I look back at Joey.

I want to tell him it will all be okay. That we can fix what they have broken. That he should join ZinnWazRight69 and start shitposting on Reddit. That memes are his goddamn right as an American.

But instead I bear hug him, trying to ignore the mechanical movements of his jaw against my shoulder. Wishing I could say something, anything, but my own mouth keeps the chant going.

Tap Tap Tap.

It's the only thing I can do.

Tap Tap Tap.

I hold him close, tap tap tapping on his skull until his jaw slows and he finally shuts up.

02 / COMPLETE SHORT FICTION

Cruella De Raven

ABSURDIST DARK COMEDY

The smell of varnish has crept north, up from the theater stage, thick and chemical, as I stare down at the five-pronged silver talons nailed to my feet. Opening night is over. The applause, sweet and reverent in its rhythmic encore, has long since dissolved into the ether. Hours ago, the Athenaeum brimmed with tech hands, directors, stars, assistants. Now they are gone. Even their mess, the cigarettes, the spilled booze, the tinted brushes, the tri-color lipsticks, all wiped clean.

Butch, our beloved director, holds up a finger as I waddle through his door.

“Sqwaaa.”

He presses a finger to his lips. The Chicago Tribune, he mouths.

I dance from foot to foot, surrounded on all sides by square-cut glass, half-forged prosthetics, cauliflower ears, aviary slit eyes, flesh-colored lips, gray slabs of unformed putty shoved into Ziploc bags.

I flutter my wings. “Sqwaa. Sqwaa.”

“Hang on,” he yells, giving a hopeless shrug “Reviews, man.” His rounded face is flushed, the phone pressed to his ear, his forehead red where the Botox struggles to hold his brow as he steps out, the door falling shut.

My bladder aches. My neck itches where the jelly has metastasized into opaque clumps. The weight of the costume drives itself vertebra by vertebra down my spine, finally settling into a deep hawkish ache behind my knees.

I wait. Hand fisted, full feathered, chicken-pacing until I realize the trap.

“SQWWAAA,” I call, over and over, first at the shut door, then to my reflection, my friend-of-a-friend in the mirror. I shove my feathered carriage against the door, hoping it would give. It doesn't. The knob is unimpressive but deeply functional. I kick at its weak alloy, talons scraping its sides. I press the crook of my neck against its curved metal shape, folding myself into an upside-down U, pulling, twisting, limboing, sweat puddling above my ass.

I sink mid-calf against the wall terrified of letting the floor swallow me up.

My eyes dart from analog to digital. One hour, then two, now three.

My reflection, my costume. Cruella de Raven. A masterpiece of murder, a feathered monstrosity, double plucked and spread wide across my body. My face is stretched long, devoured by an oblong black beak. Above it, my eyes lie buried behind two wet, glistening holes sunk deep into a glossy raven skull. And beneath all those hand-sewn feathers and screw-turned machinery is a layer of skin-sucking latex.

Butch warned me “Transformation is an ugly process,”

They brought in a large white tub of lubricant. Jórge and Gorge, Butch’s costume assistants, worked me into the suit by degrees. Jórge hauled the heavy latex upward while Gorge smoothed the skin already covered. The material clung like a leech to every rough patch of thigh and ass as Jórge ladled more and more lube until there wasn't an inch of flesh not wet and slick. My little-man hideaway, commonly known as a modesty cloth, was insufficient. My Prince Albert bobbed visibly beneath it as their hands relentlessly dragged the slick black suit higher.

It squeezed my thighs, molding its way up around the heavy hairy cheeks of my ass, straightening my spine until the little metal teeth were pulled together and zipped up.

“It suits you,” Butch said when he came to inspect their work.

He reminded me that he picked me out of the endless Rolodex of desperate theater gays as he slid on the laquered, black feathered coat and taped and glued me in. Fans were plugged into the bursting extension cord, blasting cool air to keep me from overheating. Gorge grabbed a bottle of champagne and poured it liberally down my throat to celebrate.

“Ten thousand hours makes a master. A thousand gets you one hell of a costume.” Butch said.

The overcarriage was rounded metal and bone, a massive exoskeleton that lent me a deceptive girth. A thick safety strap went under my armpits and buckled against my chest.

“Glug, glug, little bird” Jórge soothed as I took another chubby-cheeked pull of champagne.

The mask came next, and I bent over for Mother’s Little Helper. Sniff Sniff as I chased the tiny white crystals, trying not to flap my wings so the drugs wouldn’t go flying.

“We’re ready,” Jórge said, dragging a finger through the last of the powder and licking it clean.

The mask wasn't the crudest part. Yes, it very nearly blinded me, made my world into two narrow raven slits. But the vocal “enhancement”, that was the bitch of it. The crow sound, it turns out, was hard to make, beyond my vocal ability. So they devised a sort of crow call, a muffled gag that used my natural passage. The sound vibrated through it, striking the device and passing back out, until no matter what word came forth, all that emerged was some variation of aviary.

“Skwwwa,” I tested.

That was hours ago. The jellied lubricant slicks my calves and thighs, pools beneath my plump ass, and leaks between my legs in a steady drip that's become an hours-long basting broth of balls and sweat.

Drip. Drip.

The metal crunches.

Drip. Drip.

At last I knock the knob loose, and the door creeps open.

The stage is dark and a welcome relief. I move through the heavy curtains to the back door, which is mercifully propped open. A rusted can filled with cigarette butts leads me out into the blessed night. I spread my wings. “CAWWW,” I cry in delight.

Usually the Athenaeum’s narrow alley is crowded with smokers, but now all is silent. The moon hangs, a waxing gibbous above me, and I inhale what fresh air I can, sewage and garbage cans be damned.

I’m sixty-four blocks from Butch’s apartment but only twelve from mine. Downstairs Eddie will be awake. I just have to get there.

The traffic light glows green with no cars in sight. Lakeview has always been a sleepy little pocket at this hour, so I spread my wings wider and take the road by foot, talons clicking against the empty asphalt.

I spot a few lookie-loos smoking outside Cody's Public House.

“CAW…. CAWWW.” I bark at them.

I cut through a side alley and look up at a dozen dark windows until I find a beacon in a second-floor window. He's standing there, immovably beautiful, skin still wet and pink from

the shower, a white towel slung low around his waist. His chest is muscled, rocky arms clearly defined, yet somehow soft in that plucked, mammalian sort of way.

I can't tear my gaze away. A sick, twisting hunger rises in me. I long to lick the water from the groove between his pecs, to press my beak to that smooth, living skin, to feel his mustache catch in the seams of my feathers.

I think of flying up to the fire escape when a fat brown rat brushes my ankle. I jerk and fall to the side knocking over some trash bins watching the bastard dart into a soggy Giordano's box. Several little rat heads peek out, blinking up at me and a horrible, sagging loneliness opens inside me.

Then I hear the scrape of a window. "Hey," a voice yells. His soft doe eyes meet my dark slits.

Sweet Helen, make me immortal with a kiss.

'What the fuck are you doing?'

'Skwwwaak!' I panic."

I run, wings flapping uselessly at my sides. I can hear the jelly sloshing around my ankles as more windows open. I zig zag through narrow alleys, unable to turn my head until finally, my dark third floor apartment appears.

I paw uselessly at the intercom, my beak mangling one code after another.

"Skwaaa" Eddie will be awake.

I lurch around to the narrow gangway and begin climbing the iron fire escape. The latex makes every rung a struggle. I slip; my claws screech down the metal, my beak catching, throwing my neck back. Skwwwaak.

Inch-by-inch I fly myself higher.

At last I reach Eddie's window and rap my beak frantically against the glass.

Tap Tap. The glass is thin and I'm careful not to break it.

"Sqwaaaa".

Eddie's chubby face appears. He's got on a sweat-stained white shirt that balloons past his knees.

"Shit. Justin is that you?"

Skwwwaak. Skwwwaak.Skwwwaak! I nod desperately.

“Alright. Alright chill.” He holds out his hands and I shimmy-squat through the window. The outer carriage gets caught and he has to help me fold my wings tight before I can fit through. His beefy hands keep me mostly upright.

“Jesus. You doing the furry thing?”

I lie on my back, chest heaving giving my best attempt at a middle finger.

I hear him move through his kitchen. He comes back with a pair of scissors.

I panic and wiggle back and forth as he comes for my head.

“Dude hold still”. I wiggle further

One thousand hours makes you one-tenth a master. A thousand hours in glue and feather and bone.

“Sqwwaa, sqwaa”.

He puts the scissors down and goes again for my head. He pulls, and it feels as if my whole body is rupturing. He plants a knee on my chest and yanks again.

‘SQWAAA, SQWAAAAA’ Then the glue gives. The mold, the feathers, the voice box rip loose. Air and light and my own pungent human smell wash over me.

“Buckles… first. On my chest. I rasp. Two big ones on the sides.”

Eddie’s hands work the buckles open easily. Click. Click. The heavy carriage slides to the floor. My hands are free.

Together we push and pull at the latex skin. It peels off slowly with wet, obscene sucking sounds. Beneath the suit my skin is blotchy and thick with raised red goosebumps.

“You okay?” Eddie asks.

“Fuck No.”

03 / COMPLETE SHORT FICTION

Crumb-Struck

WORKPLACE SATIRE / LITERARY FICTION

The morning meeting is just starting as I peel off my coat. I look for Richie even though I know better. Creatives are typically exempt from these mandatory little get-togethers. The door shuts, and now we're all crammed into the white-on-white staff room. Towers of boxed iMacs crowd us in further. There aren't enough chairs, and I hate that I'm forced to stand already. I rock my heels back and forth for warmth as the air conditioner blows aggressively down on us dozen or so part-timers.

Chris, today's prick-of-a-morning manager, raises an eyebrow at me and slides a wide smile across his face. He has a habit of pinching my cheeks.

Every morning it's the same goddamn reminders. Doesn't he realize how much collective college debt is in this room? You really think we can't remember three numbers? It's the same sales goal every frickin day. Apple's official policy when it comes to raises and promotions is that the numbers don't matter. We spend every meeting on them anyway.

Concrete goals for concrete floors. It's never about the money. Protection plans. Creative classes. Email addresses. Hard drives. Cloud space. KA-CHING, KA-CHING. Back up your backups. Apple's your family. Blah blah blah.

"They need us," Chris says. "So if you're not sure what the answer is, don't forget—" He stops, raises his arms like a conductor, and we all join in like good little part-timers—"Let's find out together."

The cold air pimples his fat nipples through a blood-red holiday shirt as he waves us out, back to the starting line we go.

In the beginning, I believed it. We were good Samaritans, altruistic capitalists. Salaries don't matter. Shhh, you never talk about them. But now I know I'm making more than James. James has worked here for two years and I know James makes more than the old guy with the mustache who's still mourning Steve Job's death. The one who cracked his head on the floor yesterday. The one whose neck flushed a dark, mottled brown as we waited for the ambulance. I sold three AppleCare protection plans while we all pretended not to notice. Computers are so fragile. KA-CHING!

Chris the Dick corners me near the iPhone cases. His hand glides over my cheek, pauses at a small cluster of pimples, then gives the flesh a fresh pinch. He licks his lips in anticipation, "You gonna beat yesterday's record?" I watch him wipe his fingers on his pants afterward. A small stain of sweat and grease blooms on his khakis near his crotch. I stare at it, a heavy feeling pulling at the backs of my knees. After he walks away, I tell myself next time I'll smack him. I try to forget that I said the same thing last time.

I spot Richie's blond curls ducked in close with one of his regulars. I think about how cold his side of the bed was this morning. The girl he's working with gives me a wave when she sees me. All his regulars are women, and they tell me how lucky I am. Every goddamn day.

"He's so kind. So attentive. You really hit the ding-ding jackpot with this one," they say.

We haven't had sex in three weeks.

He says I'm needy. That I stink. That my hair is a mess. That he's too tired from work. That the hour difference between our schedules, his full-time and mine part-time, is the chasm that keeps us apart.

My knees begin to ache. To distract myself I pinch the numb spot between my thumb and forefinger, get a good chunk of my palm and squeeze until the blood rises.

The morning rush isn't for sales. It's for creatives. Handsome, patient employees teaching lonely, middle-class Connecticut blondes how to make memories. I busy myself wiping down displays, re-arranging lettered blocks, keeping busy to keep busy. I hear a laugh and see the customer Richie's working with hand him a twenty, slipping it under the table while he pretends to blush.

Chris pats my shoulder where my bra strap sits. I can feel his finger linger on the heavy band.

"Hey, kiddo," he says. "Break's coming down a little early today."

I won't get another for hours.

The mall hasn't shaken the sleep from its eyes yet, so I browse. My fingers brush J.Crew's polyester blends, jangle weak plastic chains at Claire's. Godiva will open later, and I'll watch through Apple's glass windows as they dip strawberries into warm milk chocolate. I like the hard shell it forms around the soft flesh of the berry as it cools. When you break them open, there are small indents from the seeds. Red strawberry residue, like my own tiny pin-pricked pimples. Sometimes I lick them, my tongue tracing the grooves.

Barnes & Noble is always open and almost always empty. It's at the far end, a five-minute walk if I hoof it. I've had my eye on a frosted chocolate cupcake in the bookstore café since last Monday. For all I know it could still be the same one. My phone buzzes against my left butt cheek. More reminders. Dismiss. Dismiss. Richie convinced me to spend my life savings on this thing, the entirety of my high school Blockbuster money, and I can't remember why.

After the punishing, utilitarian cold of the Apple Store, the café is hot, humid. Sweat pools beneath my breasts. The cupcake looks incredible today. I discreetly snatch a few photos and slide them into the album I've curated for food porn. I trace a finger along the glass case where the cupcake sits. My body heat fogs the surface and I slide my finger along the condensation leaving a single line separating us. This beauty looks so moist today. Dark at the bottom, dense at the top. I can feel saliva pooling underneath my tongue as I close my eyes.

When I open them, I can feel eyes on me. The Macintosh hangs heavy across my breasts. Sometimes people know me. More and more, people I'm sure I've never met before. I've been asked to fix iPhones, to find emails, what my schedule is, if I'm single.

I find a corner in the Tech & Electronics section and pop out my retainer, a web of saliva stretching from my lips as it pulls like fresh cheese, then drop it onto a clean napkin. I shake my Adderall bottle. Rub my thumb over the smudge-proof Helevitica. tikka… tikka… The pills dance around one another, tikka tikka. I press down and a pretty cobalt blue prize slips out. Winner winner, chicken dinner. I swallow. Replace the cap. Give them another shake…. tikka… tikka… They all shout.. Shh! A balding retiree taps my shoulder, one hand on his cane, the other pointing at my chest, smiling. His breath is hot, apple cider vinegar on his tongue. My stomach drops. I bolt back to the store before he can ask me a question.

I'm hiding in the toilet. I swipe through my cupcake photos, adding the dulcet tones of "Hello" by Lionel Richie as I zoom in on today's feature. I swipe through filters. Here it is in the Wild West. Now it's a depressed Parisian in black and white. God I'm hungry. I should be out on the floor. It's lunchtime. The Genius Bar is probably backed up, but I can't make myself rush. Not after last week.

"You're too valuable in sales," Chris said, blocking me off from the interview cubicle. "Your part-time flexibility is a huge asset. The company needs you where you are. Besides, you're still young. You really want all this extra responsibility?"

He smiled and held out a damp low five. "Come on, kiddo. You really gonna leave me hanging?" I gave him a slap, his sweat lingering on my palm, and watched him cross a red mark where my name was listed for a full-time position.

It's been too long, and I'm worried if I don't flush it will seem suspicious. I shove the sole of my shoe onto the chrome handle and lean in, pressing down again and again. Water tears loose as the bowl fills its throat, swallows, refills, again and again. The sound stacks until it becomes one long noise. WHRRRSHHH. It's all I can hear. I think about flushing my numbers. The water surges back, spits flecks at my legs and crotch again and again until someone knocks on the door.

My stomach burns, painful knots stacking on top of each other, shoving nausea up my trachea. I clutch my arms around the worst of it. Customers zigzag through our open glass doors, flagging us down. I push past a mother with twin toddlers, squat low behind one of the displays.

Tikka. Tikka.

I shake my Adderall bottle. I unscrew the cap and slide one down. I rub my thumb over my lips, spreading saliva again and again to wet any residue.

Come on. Work you bastards. Come on. I have to work.

I click. I drag. I reset passwords. I resurrect photos. I shove shiny new replacements into the hands of shiny new students. My voice booms as I ask them to test feats of strength. Arms shake as they overhead press variations of Mac Pros and MacBook Airs. I remind them that once they own them, they'll have to carry them everywhere.

When they've decided, I guide them through the grief of letting their old electronics go. Laptops can be bricked but are not bricks. Recycling is reincarnation. Consumerism is rebirth. At the end, I make a small fireball explode on the screen and watch their faces light up while the acid in my stomach burns brighter.

I sell my first computer without any upgrades. Then another. Then another. We have a reselling problem. Chris pulls me aside. He tells me the numbers don't matter as he explains that I'm fucking his up. Spit lands on my lanyard, my collar, even my chin, as he goes over the metrics from this morning's meeting. I wipe my face with the back of my hand and pull out my phone. I noticed the cupcake's wrapper was pinched tighter at the base today, shiny where the oil had started to soak through. I've never asked if it was organic but I'll just pretend it is.

I try not to look at Richie. Try to imagine he isn't ten feet away. He was so terrible at sales when he first started they promoted him. He loves reminding me, loves that he makes more money than I do. He's five years older than me and he's never offered to pay the electric once.

My mother introduced us after one of her sessions. Insisted I meet Richie. She smoothed the little creases in my sleeves afterwards and said, “this is the kind of man you want.”

He’s working with a girl my age right now, he angles his body toward her without turning his head. He hasn’t bought groceries in a week.

I smile and she smiles as I interrupt.

“Richie, can you…,” He keeps smiling but his eyes slide past me, “would you pick up a few things for dinner?”

“Of course.” We are all still smiling.

She laughs at something he’s pulled up on the iPad, she touches his hand. I take that as my cue and leave. Loser. I slump to the end of the store, a whole fifteen feet of space between them and my crushed ego.

My left butt cheek goes off. He can’t get the groceries after all. They walk out together, a few minutes later, his Carhartt slung over one shoulder. I stare at the cement. My knees hurt.

James comes over to join me. James is a slob. Across from me is Anthony. Anthony once tried to convince me he could read hieroglyphics. Next to Anthony is Nancy, chin bobbing; she believes everything Anthony says.

Grease stains darken James’s collar. He’s always chewing. We aren't supposed to eat on the floor and his tongue tries to hide it by pushing the little bits of Stouffer’s meatloaf he keeps in tiny, parceled Ziploc bags toward the back of his throat. His body odor is permeated by oversalted beef. I like it. I find myself drifting towards him, taking discreet whiffs. Swallowing little gulpfuls of air hoping to fill up.

My brain tries to float away, but it is magic hour. Sundown. The monitors shift out of their cold, venal blue. The screens catch it one at a time as orange light breaks apart, jumping from monitor to monitor, fracturing across my body in shards of oranges and reds as the colors wash over me. The store is packed with customers stopping in after their full-time jobs. People move fast now. Hands wave in my face. Fingers hook into my collar. Someone taps my shoulder. I’m sidechecked by Ms. Sherman, a chunky woman who used to teach sex-ed at my high school. She insists I consent to helping her first.

Nancy drops her second iPod. It crashes to the ground and we all pretend not to notice. I can see Chris frothing as he goes to pick it up.

When it's over. When I've flushed the last five minutes of my shift away, hiding again. I'm exhausted. But I find myself power walking back to the bookstore. One more visit. I just need to see it.

The line behind the counter is empty. It would be so easy. I have thirty-six dollars left this week. I press a hand just above my pelvis, feeling the stubborn bloat. The other hand tickles the cold glass. I want it. God. Do I want it. I give my Adderall bottle a little shake, tikka tikka, and slide another pill down my throat. Fuck. I'm gonna be short this month.

#

I can't run. The store has worn me bowlegged. I look up into the crowd of winter trees. It's dark, and their little scabby branches are shaking their fists at me, like they know what I've done. The gutters are packed with leaves and old dirt. Water breaks loose, splashing all over my sneakers. I throw my hood up, but I can feel eyes everywhere, stripping through my layers, seeing what I've hidden against my chest.

I'm almost home when someone across the street waves me over.
"Sweetheart."
Then louder, "Sweet-heart!"

I see his hungry eyes, his cane taking big lunges forward, and I shove myself through the door. Sweet curlicues of weed greet me along with half dozen new dishes crowding the sink. There's a Planet Pizza box on the kitchen table, open and empty except for a greasy-dark triangle where a lone slice sits.

Richie's headset is plugged in. His handsome elven avatar slashes monsters; ooze and ash spray cinematic blood across the screen. He's been smoking in the apartment again. I want to open the windows, but I can't afford to let the hot air out.

I start stacking dishes. My thumbs push through dried grease, crusted ketchup. I rinse one glass. Then another. Hot water sloshes against the rim, laps the metal sides, runs down the counter, and splashes onto my chest. The Macintosh darkens where the water soaks through.

The cotton turns cold when Richie comes in.

"Oh," he says, that same smile he uses on the ladies at the store sliding into place. His teeth have started yellowing these last few weeks. "Hey. You didn't have to do that." He puts a fresh greasy plate in the sink.

"Someone had to."

I turn the hot water further, grab the little smiley scrub brush my mother bought us for extra difficult messes, and tear into the pizza grease. My hands are burning. The water's too hot.

He opens the fridge and lets it hang open. There's nothing inside worth looking at and he knows it.

"You eat yet?" he asks.

"No."

Cardboard scrapes the table as he picks up the last slice. I turn my head and watch as he peels a thick layer of congealed cheese off with his fingers and plops it onto his waiting tongue.

"There was pizza," he says, chewing. I can hear his back teeth working through the cheese. "I figured you weren't hungry."

I look down at my hands. Color has come back to them, flushed and red, except for that one spot that's stubbornly white. I rub the pad of my thumb against it as hard as I can. Why is it still so fucking numb? The water is nearly to my elbows now. It's gonna spill over. I'll have to clean that up, too.

He leans against the counter beside me, close enough that I can smell him. The fridge door is still open. I paid seventy-five dollars for electricity last month.

I used to love the way he smelled. I'd sniff his armpits, the back of his neck, hold a T-shirt against my face. It made my pussy wet.

Last month I tried to smell his armpit. He pushed my head away. Told me I was nasty.

"You're mad," he says. "I can tell."

"You could have left me a slice."

"I needed it," he says as he chews. "You know how today was."

"I was there."

"But you're in sales. You don't get how hard it is to be creative. I'm essential to the brand."

The fridge door is still open.

"Sales is just as esse—"

He interrupts me. Moves his arm forward and shuts off the water before I can grab the glass, the one with fresh lipstick still on it. He was my creative once upon a time. His curly blond hair is fresh. He must have showered right before I came home. I keep forgetting how handsome he really is.

“Okay. Okay.” He pauses. “Do you want me to say I’m sorry?”

I stare at him.

“You’re making this bigger than it is,” he says. “It’s just pizza.”

“You know this isn’t about the—”

“I didn’t ask you to clean.”

“No,” I say. “You just expected it.”

The sink gurgles as he pulls the drain. He slides his lips close to my ear. The water finally sloshes as it sinks down and down, belches, then goes quiet.

“Why are you like this?”

I look at my hands. “I don’t know.”

“Oh, shit.” He stares back at his screen. “Come on. Look. I gotta get back. We’re raiding.” He presses his thick, greasy lips to the side of my neck. “Hey, guys. I’m back.” I hear him laugh. They’re all laughing.

I fold the pizza box in half, force it down the mouth of the trash can.

My mother calls. I ignore it. Put my coat back on and go to the gas station down the street. It’s dark and cold, and my hands have gone dry between the knuckles. My stomach hurts and I hold my arms across my jacket.

I lock the bathroom door behind me, unzip my jacket, and pull out the crushed plastic box. I pop out my retainer, rip open the lid, marvel at the way the buttercream has curled into a little cowlick at the top. I pull it in, suck it between my lips, let it coat the back of my tongue, and then my jaw lets loose. I take bite after bite.

The cake is dense, almost damp. I chew too fast and cough as it gets stuck in my throat. I have to stop, mouth full. Crumbs stick to my tongue. Sugar coats the back of my throat. I gargle with water from the sink and keep chewing. I lick the frosting from my fingers. I suck it from the

cuticle, the pad of my thumb. I scrape what's left from the wrapper and smear it back onto the cake.

I watch myself in the mirror, sucking on the wrapper, pulling it out and pushing it back in pieces, letting my saliva dissolve the last of it, getting every ounce of pleasure before swallowing it down. I stare past the smattering of graffiti on the glass, lift my shirt, suck in until I can count each rib. I'm beginning to think the best parts of me have been replaced with small, acceptable pieces of everyone else and I'm sick of it. Maybe all I have is crumbs. But they are my crumbs and they are goddamn delicious.

04 / COMPLETE SHORT FICTION

Sushi, Please?

CHARACTER DRAMA

I stopped looking in mirrors a few months ago. It helps to slow down the creeping passage of poor choices.

Mirrors are sneaky bastards. You catch yourself—in windows, in phone screens, in the accidental reflection of a burner spoon.

Little winks, little whispers of who you are, or were, or maybe just what's left.

Now I can't stop looking.

I pinch at the loose skin around my hips. Pawing at new marks. At bumps. At a blue and green bruise already blossoming on my palm.

Bright white stretch marks spread across my outer thighs where the skin is thickest.

I trace my finger along the raised scar above my left breast where they took out my first cyst.

"You have your grandmother's breasts," my mother used to say.

Breasts aren't soft, seductive things when you break them down. They're sacks of fat, piles of tissue you grope every now and then to keep your dead mother happy. To make sure the thing that killed her mother doesn't kill you.

"Check for lumps," she used to say.

And I do.

Because there is nothing more dramatic than a drug addict with cancer.

==========

I wake up sticky and shivering from the 9 a.m. air conditioning. My arms and ass are on fire. The cherry on top is the blistery rash wrapped around my torso like a fresh burn.

I lie there, staring at the ceiling, the weight of another failure pressing down as hard as any hangover ever has.

My breath rasps in my ears as I sit up.

Each thud of my heel on the hardwood sends shocks through my weak-ass bones until it reaches that little point in my brain where everything blurs, and I'm teetering on the edge of a blackout—not the fun kind.

I miss my piss-soaked sheets. The rancid smell of comfort I've been laying in for the last 48 hours.

My knees hit the floor.

The heels of my palms slam into the hardwood.

This is usually the part where I soothe my stomach with sweet little lies. False promises. Hollow vows to God.

Nausea coils from my pelvis to my spine, swelling in my chest until it tickles my uvula.

I get it, body. You're pissed at me. We don't have to be friends, but do we have to be goddamn enemies?

Spit pools in my mouth, thick and sour, my jaw locking as I gag. Acid burns up the back of my throat, and I clench my teeth, trying to keep it down.

Just work with me, okay?

The bathroom is a straight shot. 15 feet of hand laid Moroccan ceramic tile calls to me.

My palms hit the edge of the rug as I crawl forward, wispy fringe tickling my knees as my bare shins sweep across the Himalayan Silica.

Sweat slicks under the hand-knotted wool.

I cough, sharp and raw, the taste of bile creeping higher.

My pace is slowing. What is slower than a crawl?

I can hear the phone behind me, sharp and relentless. Why won't he stop calling?

I could probably still get half the value of the rug if—

A series of micro gags hit me all at once, splattering vomit across my Marc Phillips. Spit dribbles from my lips and nose, soaking into the fibers. My hands slip, the rug sticky and warm beneath me as I collapse.

The knotted design presses into my neck.

There's a burning ache between my breasts.

Deep, phlegmy breaths rattle through me, saliva pulling apart in strands between my wet fingers as I rub the hot ache.

A little bleach, I could still sell it. That’s the power of Oxiclean, right?

Another wave rips upwards as I press my tongue to the roof of my mouth, desperate to keep it in.

Close. I’m so close to the bathroom. If I can just inch—

Artificial colors burst through my sinuses, burning a path down to my lips. Snot mixed with stomach acid, dripping hot and sticky down my chin as a third wave begins.

**

My wet hair sticks to the back of my neck. The coil of cotton on my collarbone is slick with leftover conditioner.

I needed to see someone worse off than me, just to survive the morning. So, I'm cross-legged in my living room watching YouTube videos of some asshole interviewing homeless addicts for clicks.

Just an endless loop of drug addicts and trauma.

Watching all those people shake and twitch gives me vertigo.

So sad, I think, shaking my head. Such a shame. Poor things. Just terrible. Every fresh face worn down by a hard life, every bad choice boiled down to a single avoidable moment. They just needed better self control.

I take a couple of chunks out of the leftover pizza someone left for trash in the hallway. Some kid named Devin from Oklahoma is talking about his rock bottom as the stale crust of the pizza slices the roof of my mouth. I can taste blood, and I can’t stop running my tongue over it.

"I sold my mom’s TV for a fix," he says, his voice cracking—he’s that young. "Didn’t even think twice."

It’s been five minutes, and he’s still going on about it. TVs depreciate nearly as fast as cars. She’ll get over it.

I start to pick apart the congealed cheese, feeding my mouth with smaller, bird-like bits to try to soak up the blood.

"We used to steal food from gas stations," he mumbles.

That's a stupid place to steal food from. Tons of consequences with a maximum payoff of a half dozen servings of Lays potato chips.

I check my phone.

I'm 3 days sober with way too much time on my hands. I can feel everything right now.

"I told her I'd quit about a hundred times, but you know how it is," he says, staring off. "Once you start, it's all over."

I flick my tongue and try to apply pressure against the cut. It stings. The kid on the screen keeps talking. He won't shut up, his stupid dull voice going on and on.

I picked my nails clean on the first day. Cut them down to little naked husks. It feels good to attack, to rip the little edges of skin and flesh.

"I don't even remember what it feels like to be clean." Devin from Oklahoma.

He says it like it's profound. Like I haven't heard it a million times before. They all say the same tired bullshit. That they can't remember. But they're liars. Because it's impossible to forget.

Not for one goddamn second.

It's exactly why we don't stay sober.

I shut it off.

I hate this.

The ache in my body, the sting in my mouth, the bitterness that won't leave my brain.

The phone rings. James is calling again.

There's still time to pick up. I think about it. I really do. But then I don't. And then he's gone.

I owe him money. Three months of LA rent. An ungodly sum, according to Chase Bank. I wish it was just cash between us. If it was, maybe it'd be easier for him to ghost me. The truth is, James has never quit anything in his life. I consider it a real character flaw.

I mean, he's all screwed up. He spent his childhood soaking up those perfect, bite-sized TV moments of familial fantasies like "Growing Pains," "Full House," "Family Matters." I swear it gave him a complex.

All those happy, functional families. Can you imagine it? No one's mom died. Not a single one of them developed an addiction to black tar heroin.

That kind of deluded lack of realism can really mess with a person. Why else would he still be trying to help me? After everything I've done. After everything I owe him.

I've suggested therapy, but sometimes you just can't help people.

I swallow another mouthful of blood.

***

I'm wearing my dead mother's dress because it is easier than going shopping. My eyes itch. They look appropriately puffy, bloodshot, little bulbous veins sticking out against my milky sclera.

I'm holding a martini in her honor, three olives poking out of a decorative toothpick I found hidden between the pennies in the junk drawer.

I also found a bottle of expired Xanax behind the dusty Sudafed on the top shelf of her bathroom closet.

Far more exciting.

My mother was never one to indulge herself. If she had wine, it was by the glass and in appropriate sips and appropriate settings.

It gives a satisfying shake. That bottle. Little pop-pops as the pills bounce along the plastic edge.

It feels good to have them in my hand. My fingers brush the dust off and I wipe the edge of my thumb on the last towel my mother ever used.

I crack open the lid and inhale. It smells nothing like her.

When I was a child, I stabbed myself with a number two pencil, embedding a shaft of lead deep under my life line because I wanted our scars to be the same.

I check the label. 50. Let's see. Are we the same after all?

They spill out like bright pink confetti. Inappropriately festive against the dull white bathroom tile.

I start to count.

3, 6, 9, 12…

My lips are dried out. Chanel's Coco Flash coats the dry cracks. My mother's favorite color.

15, 18, 21…

I breathe out, nose and mouth working together until there's nothing but carbon monoxide in my lungs. I drain my elegant martini and lick the middle, where flecks of Belvedere have settled under the pits of the olive, bitter and sharp against my tongue.

I wish I had something to chase away the taste.

So I pick up one of the tiny pink pills and swallow.

Much better.

24, 27, 30, 33…

The dress I'm wearing is tight around my breasts. It pulls at my shoulders, making my back ache.

My mother would have been furious.

"Take it off! You're stretching it out!"

"It's not even that tight, mom."

"Not that tight? You're practically spilling out of it. That fabric wasn't made to suffer."

"I'll take it off in a minute," I snap back.

"In a minute? By then, it'll be ruined. God, you don't respect anything."

A soft knock at the door. My stomach twists as reality swallows the edges of my memory.

"Allie. Are you… Are you okay?"

He's standing in the doorway. My James.

He still has his suit on from this morning.

I can’t stop thinking about how badly he’s outgrown his baby face. His broad shoulders and thick neck just don't match. But his hair. My mother loved his hair. She said hair like his was a gift from God.

His hair was a gift and my tits were a curse.

I used to love his thick, black, curly hair. It used to smell like the sun.

Now it smells like wet earth. Like the ground we just shoved my mother into.

“Mothers die.” I can feel my eyes welling back up.

It comes out wrong. The inflamed fleshy walls of my throat scrape against each other every time I swallow.

I keep counting.

“She had to have taken at least one,” I tell him.

36, 39, 42…

“Everyone's waiting,” James says patiently as he crouches down.

I can see he wants to touch me. I can’t remember the last time I let him.

“I need to know.”

45, 47…

But I can't get to 50 because it’s already in my system. Already playing with my synaptic nerves.

Why didn't she touch them? Was she afraid she’d never stop?

“Have you eaten anything?" James asks.

"Yes." The Xanax was starting to kick in. It felt… it felt.

“Allie,” he tried again, “what can I do?”

“Why did she have to die now, when I loved her the most?”

Pain bubbles up, gassy and unwelcome, but I shouldn’t be feeling anything right now. I should be numb.

I take another pink pill.

“What a bitch.”

==========

I threw the rug off the balcony. Below, the backyard sloped into a cluster of oak trees. The grass had burned off years ago in the LA sun, leaving it barren and empty. I’d already used my last box of tissues on the rug, blotting with cold water, just like Mommy taught me. An hour later, it still stunk: vomit and childhood, inexplicably linked.

It went over easy enough in the end. The tissues floated after it, little angels, sticky and spent.

The sky wouldn't stop folding in on itself. Pink and blue hues churning together as the streetlights winked on, one by one.

I want a drink more than anything in this life. More than I want to pick up the phone and tell James I’m sorry. More than I want to see my dead mother again.

I need a hit of adrenaline. Something, anything, to shut up this screaming need that won't stop clawing at the back of my skull.

And I’m twitching, just like dear old Devin from Oklahoma, and my nose won’t stop running.

But I threw out everything worth a shit.

Even the stuff that barely counts.

But I’m not perfect. I rush to the back of my closet, digging through my Kate Spade purse, where I used to stash Adderall in those little hidden pockets—but that’s gone, too.

My left arm aches as I swing the medicine cabinet wide, but that's bare as well. Nyquil, Dayquil, even my goddamn Pepto Bismol—all of it, gone.

That voice. That little nagging voice that told Dr. Meyers he could go screw himself last week when he suggested rehab.

I hate that voice right now.

And all these bad, disgusting, painfully real feelings are bubbling up to the surface. All this cultish adult responsibility, clawing at me, reminding me I’m broke. My eyes dart to the stack of overdue bills in the corner. The eviction notice I ripped off my door.

I shove my head under the kitchen sink. The water's freezing, and I jerk back, hitting my crown on the spout.

"Goddamnit?!"

My eyes connect with a bag of organic fair trade locally sourced Colombian dark roast I bought back when disposable income was an actual resource.

Coffee.

The poor addict's cigarettes.

Hope. Sweet, acidic hope.

I'm tearing open drawers, sliding my hands in between avocado slicers, garlic peelers.

Egg separators, melon ballers, butter curlers, mini cheese graters.

I threw out all my grinders. Even the one for the goddamn coffee.

What kind of twisted son of a bitch—but I'm nothing if not a problem solver.

I've got a wooden cutting board and a knife out. It's comically large. The knife. I never cooked, even before I started using.

The blade's handle is smooth over polished wood. My palm feels numb and there's a static buzzing in my left ear.

I try to mince the roasted beans. Or dice, depending on how you look at it.

They don't break open easily. Bursts of caffeinated dust and chunks of the coffee carapace litter the board.

I don't have time for this. I need to feel it now.

It occurs to me what a bad idea this is.

I slipped my phone into my pocket, and now it's vibrating against my thigh. Small jolts, sharp and insistent, right on my pelvis. Reminding me that I am dangerously close to becoming a squatter.

I lean over the pile of coffee dust, pinching one nostril closed. The sharp bitterness of acidic coffee slams into my sinuses. My nose tingles, then throbs, as my eyes water uncontrollably.

The jagged edges catch in my throat, triggering my gag reflex. Involuntary contractions send waves of nausea to my gut as my throat spasms, refusing to let the bitterness settle.

Mind over matter.

Gotta look at the big picture.

Where was all this fuss from my body years ago?

And holy shit, this feels good. Adrenaline, you big old bastard, it's good to feel ya.

I swallow again.

Wipe my tongue on the coffee grounds still left on the cutting board.

Why the hell do people go through all this trouble to drink coffee when this is infinitely more effective?

I keep dicing. The shaking hasn't stopped, but now it's the good kind of shaking. The kind that's itching for a sense of purpose.

I mean, coffee is hardly considered cheating, right?

There's no real substitute for good old-fashioned, salt-of-the-earth drugs, but I gotta try.

All I want is to lay on something that isn't the floor. But I threw all of my shitty furniture over the balcony last night.

A lamp mocks me as it dangles from a pine tree. The rest of my stuff got swallowed up by the woods.

Squatters don't get back security deposits, and right now, all this shit in my life is standing between me and a $3,000 payday. U-Hauls just aren't in the budget when you've spent all your mom's money on Uber Eats and Uber drugs.

The bed was surprisingly easy to toss, but that dining table? That was a bitch to hurl over. One of those Silent Generation pieces, heavy with the weight of a lifetime of repression. It took some serious centrifugal force to get that thing over. The balcony's glass cracked from the strain when I tried to balance it on top. But I guess that's the price you pay to get rid of things you don't want.

My eyes dart between the uninspired artwork still hanging on level hooks, the dead plants still sitting neatly in their cute little IKEA pots, the throw pillows, the maps, the picture frame

James gave me with a quote about second chances. All of it—a direct threat to that cash in hand.

I head into the bedroom and start emptying drawers, grabbing handfuls of clothes and cradling them against my chest before chucking them over the balcony. I avoid the broken glass as I hurl summer T-shirts and soft sweaters into the air.

I grab a cashmere sweater, worn thin from too many washes. It smells like the hospital. For a second, I catch a whiff of her.

I hesitate.

"You're so angry, Allie. All that fight in you—where does it go when it's over?"

It doesn't. Grief keeps it alive, filling the space where her love used to be.

I toss it. It doesn't fall fast enough.

I run the next batch under the sink. I get water everywhere. The carpet turns wet and squishy beneath my feet, but it's worth it. The added weight makes the clothes fall over the railing faster. Nothing gets stuck on errant branches this time.

==========

"It's okay to ask for help!" the sign still reads.

My scar aches. My coke finger moves over it, just above my breast, again and again, trying to smooth away the raised edges.

The waiting room is a direct assault of primary colors, walls painted cherry red and sparkly blue, handprints of happy little patients smeared across brightly colored construction paper.

My skin itches and I can smell cheap disinfectant and plastic dinosaurs.

Dr. Meyers' secretary has dark braids and meaty eyebrows.

"You are aware that he only works with children?"

"I know that. I used to be one."

"A child, or a patient?"

"Both."

I've decided I hate her.

She nods her head. Scribbles something and tells me to take a seat.

I had to take the bus. Do you know how fucked the LA transit system is?

I slump into one of the chairs farthest in the corner. I turn my body in. I feel good. Really good. I shot up in the parking lot behind the dumpster a few minutes ago.

I wanted to be in good shape for our reunion session.

Sound of mind and body.

I try not to touch anything, dropping my chin to my chest and shutting my eyes against the lurid display of colors.

I wasn't quite dreaming. It's something else. I call it going away. Where nothing hurts, and everything is as warm as a mother's uterus.

She was shaking me. Her acrylic nails pressed into my bare arms.

"Allie, you have no respect. You're stretching everything too far out. Wear yourself properly, for God's sake."

"What?"

But when I looked up, it was just me and sausage brows behind her big plastic desk.

"Ma'am. Ma'am," she kept yelling.

"What?"

"Go in."

It was like stepping back into a childhood memory. My body felt alive. Electric. Giddy off all this gaudy nostalgia.

Everything was the same. Torn apart and reassembled. His desk. The worn out burgundy couch.

The only thing that had changed was him.

Dr. Meyers had lost all his good-natured weight. He was sallow around the eyes and clean shaven.

I picked up a Mr. Potato Head, holding it awkwardly before the mustache snapped off, rolling under the couch.

I dropped down, shoulder to the floor, fingers scrabbling at the plastic.

“Got it.”

He smiled. “Please, have a seat.”

I put the Mr. Potato Head back. Left his little mustache beside him on the table.

“Before we begin, I just want to share my condolences about your mother. I was very saddened to hear of her passing. Cancer is a terrible thing.”

So that’s where he wanted to start. My dead mother.

My face felt tight, and suddenly everything itched. Carpet fibers, probably. Cheap office carpet. I scratched at my collar bone.

“Yeah, well. Mothers die. It’s kind of the thing they do. Their big reward for all that self-sacrifice.”

I think I freaked him out. I talked too fast, couldn’t sit still. The hit I just took was too strong. I wanted to hear what he had to say, but I wasn’t sure I’d stopped talking.

“You sounded like you might be having a hard time on the phone,” he interrupted.

“I think I’m having a hard time adjusting.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes. Definitely, absolutely. It’s an adjustment issue. The transition from adolescence to adulthood isn’t going as smoothly as I’d hoped.”

“But aren’t you 33?”

I stood up and wandered over to the toys. The ones kids fidgeted with as they spilled their guts. I moved little bobs and squiggly lines back and forth on green-tinted wire.

“You know… when your problems feel so bad, there’s no way they’ll ever feel better? You talk and talk, and it’s just… nothing. How many of these kids did you promise things would get better for? Did you ever check in, see if those promises meant anything?”

“Do you wish I’d checked in after we concluded our sessions?”

“Maybe. I don’t know.”

The second I said it, my stomach lurched. I grabbed the metal bucket next to the couch and spilled my guts right next to a brightly colored xylophone.

Dr. Meyers handed me a box of tissues. “Are you all right?” he asked.

“I’m fine,” I said, wiping my mouth with the back of my hand.

He picked up the phone.

“Don’t.”

“I’m not qualified for this kind of therapy.” His eyes darted to the bucket, which was starting to smell, and I could see the panic in his puffy blue eyes—the way he couldn’t hide it when he handed me the referral.

I could still see him, but he couldn’t see me anymore. I was just this skinny bitch he wanted to get rid of.

Fifteen minutes. That’s how long it took for him to write me off.

“You couldn’t even pretend to care long enough to finish the goddamn session.”

That hurt.

Screw him and his fake-ass concern.

And now it’s been three days, and no wonder so many celebrities decide to die young. Quitting feels more like failure than failure ever did.

James would call this cheating. No shades of black tar for that boy.

I’ve snorted at least a gram bag worth of the Columbian good stuff.

I grab the bag of coffee and march into the bathroom, pouring a few cups worth into the toilet, beans bouncing and clicking off the twenty-first century porcelain.

But then I hesitate, hand hovering mid-pour. I mean, it’s only coffee. Everyone drinks coffee. Sure, the crack addicts on Guerrero Street have a cup now and then, but so do the priests that hand them out.

So I put the bag to my lips, letting a few more beans slide in, and they burst brilliantly in my mind's eye and on my wet tongue.

I feel like an animal. Crouched down on all fours.

I pour the rest out and flush. All that free trade labor directly in the shitter.

I have to keep flushing as a few of the beans get stuck at the bottom, spit back out after each cycle. Getting more bloated by the second.

**

My hands are shaking. I can feel the sweat from my breasts and back pooling downwards. I pull my panties down and my ass makes direct contact. The sweet familiar scent of coffee is drowned out by the worst shit of my life. It only takes a second for my ass to corrupt every bit of breathable air. The sour, acrid smell fills my lungs.

Things begin falling out of me, unbidden by my anal clenching. My gut has become a perfect ecosystem for this absolute shit storm. I press my head to my knees. Flattening my body so that my forehead rests on my knees. It burns.

The kind of burn that could caramelize sugar and sear flesh.

James is calling. I can see his picture flashing. It's the last one we took together. Right before I went AFK.

Why did I throw out the Pepto Bismol?

A gurgling knot flows from intestines to sphincter.

Right—because all drugs are bad. Thanks, brain. Wouldn't want any of those pesky antacids to lead me back to the harder stuff like extra strength Tums.

Can you imagine? After everything I've done. What must my guts look like now? All those necessary internal organs. Barbecued, most likely.

And I'm worried about pink Pepto packets.

Jesus.

I was wrong.

Don't snort coffee.

Got it.

Can you hear me?

Son of God. I was wrong. Okay.

I’m sorry…I’m sorry.

==========

An hour goes by, then several more. My ass is still on fire and I want to quit, but I can't. My stomach burns and I don't know if this is actual hunger I’m feeling or just more of the coffee working through my screwed up ecosystem.

Actual hunger has been so rare for so long that I haven't bought food in forever. I go to my cabinets and wonder if those nursery rhyme bears were also addicts.

I think about ordering in, but my last account got suspended for too many “incidents.” I could go out.There's a convenience store a block away but that's hardly as convenient as it sounds.

Plus, I don’t have anything to wear anymore. And in this town, you are what you wear, and right now I’m wearing the body of a washed-up, lonely heroin addict who couldn’t pay their rent because mommy is too dead to care.

They wouldn't see all my potential. All this beautiful clean living. They’d only see what's left. And what’s left isn’t much.

James’s damn name lights up the darkness in my living room, which is getting uncomfortably dark considering my lamp is in a fucking tree.

Why won't he just give up? Why can't he let me go?

I hate him for still trying.

For still showing up.

For still believing in me.

There’s just a few things left. I’ll get the deposit back. They’ll hand me the check, and I’ll hand it to him. Then it’ll be over.

My stomach's cramping.

James would definitely bring food if I asked—probably show up with an entire Erewhon sushi platter, acting like I still deserved the royal treatment.

And real sushi sounds so good. Almost worth all the bullshit that would come with it.

The last thing I ordered was one of those cheap California rolls, the kind with fake crab meat dyed neon orange.

The delivery guy told me that the neon orange dye they use is made from crushed-up bugs. They mash them into a paste, soak your food in it, and call it luxury. Probably said it because I didn't leave him a tip.

And yet, here I am, reduced to craving fish paste drenched in bug juice.

It's all just chemicals anyway, probably no worse than half the shit I've smoked.

I just need to trash the rest of this life. Tear it apart, burn it down, whatever it takes to start fresh. The faster I work, the closer I get to that $3,000 and the closer I am to eating something that doesn't taste like a fucking lie.

I don't even know what I'm grabbing anymore. Toothpaste, hand towels, dishes with stupid little ducks on them that my mom said I couldn't throw away. I just need them gone.

Everything goes over. Everything gets sucked up by the void.

And then. I'm holding the last of it.

Everyone has an irreplaceable box, and this one is mine. Useless shit that, somehow, has collectively become the most defining set of physical objects I own. The ring that James wouldn't take back, the letters my mother wrote to me when I was a lonely freshman, childhood photos that I told myself were lame, and at the bottom, my first and only sobriety chip from AA.

Now I'm standing in the dark, perching on broken glass, bleeding from my big toe because my lamp is in a stupid tree and somehow there's glass everywhere.

And I can't stop feeling.

And no amount of adrenaline or freezing water is gonna stop it this time.

And I'm holding the box over the edge.

Why can't I ever see the stars?

Everything hurts.

My arm is shaking and I'm beginning to think that maybe I'm one of those poor things, one of those sad souls just like Devin.

Only I don't have a mom to steal from or fight with. I don't have someone to make it all better, because it's broken. I'm broken. And I wish I hadn't loved her so fucking much. So much that it still burns, even now.

365 days later, and I still can't stand the weight of it.

I can see the blood stains all over the carpet. Hope that doesn't count against my deposit. How much does it cost to clean up blood? It's LA. It's probably included in my lease.

My hand won't stop twitching, and all I want to do is drop it. The box. My memories. All the things that make me feel worse about being so terrible.

Drop it. "Fucking drop it." And even though I'm screaming, no one is listening to me.

Sobriety has made everything so much worse.

I don't feel clean. I feel dirty. My stomach bulges with bubble guts. I'm bleeding, cut up from the roof of my mouth to the bottom of my soul. Too sad for even my own self pity to save me.

Quitting drugs feels more like failure than failure ever did.

But I don't want to die young. I want to die old and rich and full of cool stories that don't include this one.

And it's suddenly impossible to ignore the smell of molding carpet, the broken glass, the bloody footprints.

And I know. I just know that there isn't going to be a check coming for me.

**

I wasn't there when she died. She was so mad at me that day. Furious. I was high. The good kind. The early kind, when drugs were still fun.

And I hate that I wasn't there to tell her. That I wasn't there to make it better for her the way she made my whole life better for me.

I was just so damn scared I'd end up in that same bed someday.

I throw it—the box, the last bit of me I have left. But it doesn't vanish into the black hole like I wanted. Instead, it shatters on the ground, and everything I am spills everywhere.

I can see pictures of us, my mom and me, grinning, sunburned arms slung around each other on a beach somewhere. And I can't stand it anymore. I can't stand missing you this much. I want to go away again.

But I can't stop looking. That memory—it's still bright, still alive. I hold it close, clutching it to my filthy chest, right above the scar on my breast.

I'm crying. Really crying. Choking on snot and spit.

My little broken life is scattered on the ground. I grab at the pieces, covering myself with the papers and photos. I can't find the ring. Where the fuck is James's ring?

I search on my hands and knees for a few minutes before giving up.

More time goes by. I've made a blanket of all the things that I love most, but it isn't enough.

And I pick up my goddam phone and it's me that calls this time.

"James."

"Jesus. Allie, Are you okay? I've been trying to reach you."

"I know."

"What's going on? Please just talk to me."

And for the first time in a long time, I want to.

"Do you want to go get sushi?"

05 / COMPLETE SHORT FICTION

The Flying Nun

FARCE / DARK COMEDY

I had to pee and I was afraid to die, in that order. The plane was bucking hard over the Atlantic, scaring the hell out of everyone. The airline seat was hard, unforgiving, upholstered with something that even the most generous pricks would struggle to call leather. I stuck to the thing, sweating and clenching. Trying to hold it all in. Every lurch made my sphincter squeeze in panic. The grip was so intense, I could have cracked a turd in half. Despite all the goddamn fear, my bladder wouldn't let up.

"I can hold it," I assured myself.

But this shit show was budget—no in-flight movies, no tiny bottles of tequila to keep you sane. Nothing but the endless drone of engines and the jarring shake that rippled through the cabin, reminding all of us cheap bastards that we'd royally screwed ourselves.Carol would probably have called this Karma at 30,000 feet.I checked my pockets for the third time. I rubbed the little metal flask that had been empty since we boarded.

What I wouldn't give to keep from dying sober.

I mean dying is one thing, but sober and in a pool of my own piss? I had higher hopes.

My only saving grace?

Right next to me was the hottest nun you've ever seen. Her lips, God, her lips. Wet, wide, juicy little suckers I couldn't stop staring at.

She was wearing the outfit and everything. They let her board early, right along with the screaming babies and that guy who insisted being over 65 counted as a disability. I admired her game.

My ex, Carol, hated nuns. Thought they were all brownnosers. But to be fair, her hate wasn't exactly selective. She hated our house in Reno, my mother, her mother, her job, my job, the 15 years we spent together.

And me. She definitely hated me.

On the next jolt, the nun let out a soft little gasp, her tongue flicking out just enough to catch the fervent religious spittle gathering at the corner of her mouth. She'd been praying non-stop for the last ten minutes.

Every jostle, every shake, was met with the sweetest Hail Mary, full of grace. God probably didn't have a clue what to do in a situation like this.

Tank the plane, and I go under. No great loss.

Then again, tank the plane, and his sweet little angel gets her first taste of water sports.

She glanced over at me, her knuckles bright white around around her thick little rosary.

"Would you like to pray with me?"

"Hell yeah."

Her hand reached out, laying those soft, pink, moist little nubs gently over my fingers. I wanted to lick the holy sweat from her palms. Only, I don't think my bladder could take another drop.

We caught a nasty gust of wind, and I tried to give her a reassuring wink—just as a nervous fart slipped out.

Surely she wouldn't hold a bit of turbulence-induced flatulence against a fellow child of God.

"Close your eyes," she whispered. "Let's ask for his forgiveness."

Close my eyes? Not a shot. Not when I could watch her mouth do the lord's work.

But then she froze. Her lips parted, those flushed red cheeks going green as her eyes widened in alarm. Her hand jerked away, clutching at her stomach.

She leaned forward, her eyes darting around in panic, desperately scanning for one of those emergency spew sacks.

I dug into the seat pockets in front of me, elbow deep in crumpled magazines, sticky wrappers, chewed up pen caps, loose pretzels, and a disturbing large clump of hair.

Guess barf bags are too good for economy.

"Hold on!" I screamed.

But God had other plans. She was about to blow, and on instinct, I reached out, my hand covering her mouth, her breath hot and damp against my skin.

Our eyes met and for a moment I got lost in those baby blues as the first wave of bile hit. It splattered against my skin, clinging to the creases of my palm.

I held firm, determined to be her savior as hot mucus threatened to slide through my fingers.

Slowly, she began to swallow, her throat moving in deliberate, rhythmic motions.

God may hate me. Just like he hated my father, my brother, my uncle, my second and third aunts, and that guy at the end of the cul-de-sac who kept getting arrested for DMT. But right then? I felt the call.

We had an Angel in common and she needed help. Needed tissues. Needed a nice, safe place to unburden herself. And if I could piss at the same time, well, that's a two-for-one miracle if I ever saw one.

So I unbuckled, climbed over the holy spirit, and staggered toward the john. Determined to bring back the goods.

I'm talking barf bags, tissues, water bottles, headphones, blankets, ginger ale, those fancy inflatable pillows reserved for frequent flyers.

The stewardess, who was strapped in tight, shot me a thumbs down as I lurched across the cabin. She might've also been shouting at me to sit the hell down, but my bladder was screaming louder, so I didn't really give a shit.

Just then, a bout of turbulence flicked the lights off and a chorus of screams provided the perfect distraction. I ran, stumbling, to the back, shouldering the bathroom door with a hell of a lot of force.

My armpit caught the sticky edge of the Vacant sign and I felt some of the dangly squatters underneath my pit being ripped out as the pressure slid the door sideways. I fumbled in the dim light for the lock as the plane gave another violent shudder. The walls pulsated as I leaned against the cool metal, struggling to catch my breath.

Then the lights clicked on, and I wish to God they hadn't. The bathroom was a mess. I'm talking pure chaos. The turbulence had given everything a hellish shake-up. Pink soap was drizzled with artistic flair over the rim of the toilet seat. Several used tampons had liberated themselves from the sanitary bin, inching along the piss-soaked floor like a procession of

eager, pre-metamorphosed caterpillars. Wads of toilet paper clung to the mirror, fused by clear clumps of creamy fluid that could have passed for snot but looked more like jizz.

The steel wing tipped, launching me sideways, and I stumbled, my foot skidding on the cluster of bloodied tampons. My hand shot out to brace my fall, landing in a slick smear of pink soap that sent me sliding forward, ramming the side of my face against the filthy toilet rimMy knees met solid ground, the urine soaking through my jeans.

Out of options, I interlaced my fingers in front of that toilet and appealed to a higher authority.

Dear God.

Please give me the strength to help that ridiculously hot nun in 3B. I know I'm not your favorite, I know I screwed things up with Carol. I wasn't patient enough, I drank too much, and okay, I might've called her mother a bitch one too many times. But you've gotta admit, she really is a bitch.

The plane dropped suddenly. A quick, stomach-flipping plunge that sent my forehead bouncing off the rim of the toilet.

Look, if you can just grant me the decency to piss, I swear I'll do everything I can to honor, cherish, and assist that divine piece of ass you've seated beside me. Amen.

Maybe it was divine intervention. Maybe it was just what a man has to do when faced with the defining moment of his life. When he has to choose between cowardice and courage, between pissing himself and becoming the master of his own destiny.

Determined, clutching the sink for support, I hauled my ass up.

Scuzzy hands went to adjust my fly, only to find it already hanging open. I hoped the nun hadn't seen.

I didn't have it in me to be embarrassed as I let go, relief washing over me with what might have been the most satisfying piss of my life. A good piss is a good piss, no matter the decor, but this was something else. Urine shot out of me with the force of a man half my age. Not too shabby, I thought, as my aim rang true, hitting the bowl's sweet spot.

The sink was busted, so I wiped my hands, covered in shit, piss, grime, filth, and God knows what else, on wads of tissues I grabbed by the fistful. Some of them fell like breadcrumbs behind me as I stumbled toward the galley, where I was sure supplies for first-class passengers were stashed. My sticky hands jammed into cold metal compartments, hunting

through pristine napkins, unopened wipes, lily-white vomit vessels—the kind of shit they don't waste on the likes of economy flyers.

I grabbed it all by the handful.

The turbulence intensified as I stumbled past my fellow passengers, the plane bucking back and forth. I didn't bother with the excuse mes or pardon mes, knocking into shoulders and knees, tripping over displaced limbs sprawled across the aisle.

I caught a glimpse of the promised land. My nun, just a dozen or so seats away.

A woman to my right barfed.II turned my head, and our eyes met. That same disgusted look, that streak of orange vomit tangled in her hair. God, I miss Carol.

Then the smell hit. A one two punch right to the old nasal passages. For a moment, I just stood there, stunned.

Seconds later it began.

A chain reaction—left, right, front, back—a chorus of puking on all sides.

It was at that moment I understood. God was giving me a second chance, a re-baptism of sorts. I couldn't change all the times I'd let Carol down, all the chances I'd wasted to do right by my fellow man. But right now, in the middle of this chaos, I could become a new man cleansed of all my sins.

I threw the bags into the air. They flew, their white wings gliding through the maelstrom, carrying salvation to the retching masses.

I could hear the flight attendant screaming, "Those are for Gold Member Elites!" as I pulled myself forward through a tunnel of gagging and noxious fumes.

I say pulled because we were nosediving the wrong way. That metal ass should've been down, not up, and I was practically doing chin-ups, one hand crushing the seat in front of me as my legs kicked out into nothingness.

Part of me thought about just letting go and going with God, but then the plane straightened out, and suddenly I had just enough of a chance to get back to my seat.

I ran toward her, wiping streaks of puke from my eyes and smearing it across my forehead like war paint, ignoring the stench and the burn.

There she was. My nun dressed in white. A divine vision.

I held the last bag out for her. An offering. I'd saved it, guarded it, using my body as a human shield against the chaos. And now, with trembling hands, I handed it to her, from sinner to saint.

Our eyes met, and I knew at that moment—this was it. If we made it through this, I'd join the church. I'd convince Carol to give me a second chance. Hell, I'd even cut down on calling her mom a bitch.

I opened my mouth to testify—to tell her about my conversion, my redemption, my shiny new future.

The plane jolted violently, and before she could take the bag, she puked.

I smelled it before I saw it. The unmistakable scent of unfertilized, undigested sulfur. Orange, sack-like over-easy yolks regurgitated from her gullet directly into my face.

I gagged at the taste, the worst thing I'd had in my mouth since Carol's yeast infection four Christmases ago.

She looked at me. At the bag. At the mess, the filth, the soap, and the puke. Her eyes lingered, taking it all in, and I just knew she saw past it. Past the filth, the stench, whatever was dripping down my leg. She could see what I had done. Who I truly was. Who I could be.

"Your fly is down."

"For the love of God."

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06 / FULL STAGE PLAY

We Won’t Fight

A full-length stage play by Lindsay Morris

The next section reproduces the author’s original 75-page play, including its original dialogue layout, stage directions and cast list.

We Won't Fight

By Lindsay Morris

Cast of Characters

LINDSAY:	A woman in her late 20's
NOAH:	A man in his mid 20's
SHERRI:	A woman in her late 40's
HAMMOND:	A man in his early 50's
CLIFF:	A man in his late 30's
GREG:	A man in his early 30's

Scene 1

Thursday night. Closing time at a local Jewel. Lindsay browses the wine selection. Greg an employee approaches.

GREG
Can I help you find anything?

LINDSAY
(Checks name badge)
Hi Greg.
(Shakes hand)
Could you help me find a champagne that would I don't know make my parents like each other again? What pairs well with Xanax?

GREG
Uh…
(Laughs nervously)
I don't know about that but I find tequila sometimes does the trick?

LINDSAY
It has to be champagne. We're celebrating.
(picks out a bottle)

What about this one? They look happy.

GREG
Actually, it's a rose. It says it's on super sale though. 4.99?

LINDSAY
Well is it a Chicago wine? My dad wants a Chicago wine. Are there vineyards in Chicago? Maybe on the south side?

GREG
I can't think of any but there's a lot of Chicago beer.

LINDSAY
My dad's prostate flares up when he drinks beer.

GREG

Definitely not beer then.

LINDSAY
What’s your favorite champagne, Greg?

GREG
Mine?

LINDSAY
Yeah. What do you like?

GREG
To be honest I don't really drink.

LINDSAY
That's perfect. Neither does my family. But when we do we all seem to get along a lot better.

GREG

Well.. What’s the occasion?

LINDSAY
I’m engineering a positive family experience.

GREG
Okay….Is there gonna be food? I hear red wine goes well with/

LINDSAY
I mean if my mom cooks I imagine our food will taste like guilt so maybe pizza? (Long pause)I really need this dinner to go well, Greg. What about this one?

GREG
The Apothecary Dark? I know it’s wine, and it seems really popular.

LINDSAY

When you enter the world of Apothic, you enter the world of intrigue and mystery. Lean into the fantasy. Let us beckon you forward. Apothecary Dark, so full-bodied it can’t be ignored. Does that sound good to you?

GREG

Uh…it sounds different ??

LINDSAY

My parents are meeting my fiance for the first time. I just want us to get through one dinner where we don't spend the whole time-fighting. That’s not too much to ask? There divorced. I feel like they’ve always been divorced. Are your parents divorced Greg?

GREG

My mom’s dead.

LINDSAY

Oh. God. How did it happen? I mean. Obviously, you don't have to tell me.

GREG

Um.. You know.

Lindsay

But if you want to talk about I’m here for you.

GREG

That’s okay.

Lindsay

Anyway, I’m sorry for your loss. Are you married?

GREG

Um. Yes. 3 years in March.

Lindsay
Did you get a ring? My boyfriend hasn't bought me a ring yet. He’s going to though. It’s not like he forgot or anything. I mean it doesn't mean anything. Lots of people don't have rings. Right, Greg?

GREG
Um. Yes.

LINDSAY
I mean you don’t need a ring to buy a dress. Do you? It’s not, as the saleswoman at David Bridals said “jumping the gun”?

And it's not like my family could actually scare him away. Right?

GREG
Sure.

LINDSAY
But you think it’s a good idea?

People have Family dinners all the time. Cliff. My fiance. He’s normal. He’s from the midwest. Cleveland.

He calls his mom every Thursday. They chat about the weather. The weather Greg. My mom only ever screams about the weather.

GREG
We’re closing in a few minutes.

LINDSAY
Okay, okay. I’ll take two of these.

And we still need to find that bottle of champagne.

What are you doing around dinner time tomorrow, Greg?

GREG
Oh. Um. I’m working.

LINDSAY
We should keep in touch. My name’s Lindsay. It’s rare to connect with someone right away. Are you on facebook? Or you an Instagram kind of person?

GREG
I think that’s against store policy.

Lindsay
Don’t worry. We’ll keep it on the DL. It’s just been so nice to talk to someone who really understands.

GREG
…Yeesh.

SCENE 2

Friday morning at Cliff and Lindsay's apartment. Cliff is packing the wine carefully. Lindsay is moving through piles in search of something.

LINDSAY
Have you seen my I.D? I can't find my I.D. anywhere.

CLIFF
Where did you have it last.

LINDSAY
It was right. There. I put it on the floor right there.

CLIFF
Why do you keep things on the floor.

LINDSAY
That's where I like them.

CLIFF
Why won't you let me buy you a home organizer?

LINDSAY
Because we don't need a home organizer. That's a complete waste of money.

CLIFF
Not if you are keeping things on the floor.

LINDSAY
The floor is a perfectly reasonable place to put things.

CLIFF
Says the girl who lost her I.D.

LINDSAY
I didn't lose it. You moved it. Where did you put it?

CLIFF
I don't know. I probably put it in a drawer somewhere.

LINDSAY
What drawer?

LINDSAY
Do you mean the closet?

(LINDSAY begins grabbing items from the closet. She finds her costco ID)

LINDSAY
Do you think the airport would accept a Costco ID?

CLIFF
I thought your membership expired.

LINDSAY
They don't know that.

CLIFF
What about your passport? Where’s that?

LINDSAY
Maybe a library card.

CLIFF
Library cards don't have pictures on them

LINDSAY
Can you call American Airlines?

CLIFF
You want me to call them?

LINDSAY
Yes. Maybe they can do a one-time exception.

CLIFF
For a library card?

LINDSAY
What about a yearbook? I think I still have the one from 8th grade? Have you seen it?

CLIFF
I thought you said you threw that out because your mom said you looked fat in your photo?

LINDSAY
She didn't say I was fat she said I could lose a few.

CLIFF
I’ve got a minimum 40 minute hold time. I can see what their website says.

LINDSAY
I know what their website says.

CLIFF
Ok. Relax.

LINDSAY
I’m super relaxed.

CLIFF
If we miss this flight.

LINDSAY
We aren't missing this flight.

CLIFF
I’m just saying that we can always reschedule.

LINDSAY
We can’t reschedule.

CLIFF
Why not? I’m sure your Mom would understand.

LINDSAY
You mean “your” mom would understand.

Do you know what happened when I rescheduled dinner with boyfriend number... Steve?

CLIFF
Yes. You told me.

LINDSAY
She wouldn't even let me say his name after that. He was just number 4 like he was one of those kids that the government experimented on in Stranger Things.

CLIFF
I don't think this is a Steve situation

LINDSAY
I’m still not allowed to drink Snapple Iced tea. 20 years later and my mom still hasn’t forgiven the lady for rescheduling.

CLIFF
The woman from the commercials? “Made from the best stuff on Earth”

LINDSAY
What no? Why would she have a grudge against the actor? I’m talking about the owner.

CLIFF
How does your mom know the owner?

LINDSAY
Who knows? But the lady rescheduled and bam. NO more Snapple. Do you know what it was like growing up as a kid in the ’90s and not getting to drink Snapple?

CLIFF
It sounds like your mom isn't the only one who can hold a grudge.

LINDSAY
Did the airline pick up yet?

CLIFF
I’m still on hold.

LINDSAY
Jesus Cliff. Can’t you remember where you put it?

CLIFF
Did you check your purse?

LINDSAY
Of course, I checked my purse.

CLIFF
What about your wallet?

LINDSAY
I don’t have a wallet.

CLIFF
We’ll maybe if you had a wallet you wouldn’t always be losing things.

LINDSAY
Thank you. What sage words from the guy that can't remember to pick out an engagement ring.

CLIFF
That’s a low blow. I told you it takes time. I don’t want to get you something you’ll hate.

LINDSAY
I would never hate anything you picked out.

CLIFF
Are you kidding? I brought home the wrong face wash the other day and you had a meltdown.

LINDSAY
Who thinks a charcoal cleansing mask is a face wash?

CLIFF
It’s like this every time you go see your family.

LINDSAY
Do you know what my family is gonna say if I don't have a ring?

CLIFF
What will they say?

LINDSAY
That you don't love me

(A phone rings. LINDSAY sighs and ignores the call)

LINDSAY
Again?

CLIFF
Who was that?...

LINDSAY
Who else.

CLIFF
That's the third call this morning.

LINDSAY
He keeps forgetting to tell me things.

CLIFF
Anything of importance.

LINDSAY
Other than to drink lots of fluids and to avoid airport bathrooms due to the measles outbreak.

CLIFF
That seems like conflicting advice.

LINDSAY
Are you caught up on your shots? He’s gonna ask. Make sure you tell him you’ve already had chickenpox. You have had chickenpox, haven't you?

CLIFF
I don’t know.

LINDSAY
What do you mean you don't know?

CLIFF
I don't know.

LINDSAY
Call your mother. He’ll want proof.

CLIFF
Proof that I’ve had the chickenpox.

LINDSAY
Could it have fallen inside a shoe? Have you checked your shoes. Take off your shoes.

(LINDSAY starts taking off Cliff’s shoes)

LINDSAY
Are you calling her?

CLIFF
I’m gonna hang up. This is too much.

LINDSAY
You think this is too much. I’ve been fielding calls from my father all day. I’ve lost my ID. I terrified a Jewel Osco employee last night and you’re not Jewish. Where in the fuck mother fucking fuck is my ID.

CLIFF
Why does he care if I had chicken pox?

LINDSAY
Because of his Shingles. He doesn't want you to make it worse.

CLIFF

That sounds wrong.

LINDSAY
CLIFF. Please stop trying to figure out the inner workings of my hypochondriac father and call your mother.

CLIFF
Hey. No matter what happens with your family it isn’t going to change how I feel about you

LINDSAY
You haven't met them.

CLIFF
I’ve met you/

LINDSAY
/Oh. Oh. What if you put it in your wallet? Where’s your wallet?

LINDSAY
Where’s your wallet???

(Cliff points to his jacket)

LINDSAY
No. No No…. Omg. Omg. I’m a genius. I knew you touched it.

CLIFF
“Hi Mom. Did I have the Chicken Pox?

LINDSAY
Cliff. I found it. I got it. We have to go. We’re gonna miss our flight.

CLIFF
Im asking my mom about the chicken pox. She doesn't know. She’s gone to ask my dad.

LINDSAY
Forget the chicken pox. I found my I.D.

CLIFF
But what about the shingles.

LINDSAY
Just don't go to the bathroom and you'll be fine.

SCENE 3

A kitchen table is crowded with papers and pills in the absence of family dinners.

A doorbell rings. A dog barks. Sherri screams down from the stairs.

SHERRI(VO)
NOAH'S locked out. Answer it or Nora's gonna keep barking.

LINDSAY
Doesn't he live here? Why doesn't he have his own keys?

(The Doorbell rings again and Nora begins barking again)

SHERRI
I don't want him touching my things when I'm not here. I don't trust him. Damit the Dog's barking answer the door.

(NOAH enters)

NOAH
Do you really think this dinner is a good idea?

LINDSAY
Hello to you too.

NOAH
Fine. Hello.

NOAH

Where is he?

LINDSAY

Who?

NOAH

Boyfriend number, what are we on 5?

LINDSAY

This one isn't getting a number

NOAH

Is he Jewish?

LINDSAY

No.

NOAH

Then you know he’s getting a number.

LINDSAY

Since when did mom start locking you out of the house?

NOAH

She’s still pissed about the condom. How was I supposed to know Nora was gonna stick her face in the trash and pull out my used jizz bag and bring it to mom. Thank god I tied it off.

LINDSAY

UGH (gurgle noises) Dude. Why... I thought she just found the wrapper. Your 27 years old and she’s punishing you for having sex.

NOAH

Well. At least I was careful. You should be proud of me that I’m not using the pull out method anymore.

LINDSAY

That’s not the point. You need to move out.

NOAH

You don't know what it’s like when you're not here.

LINDSAY

Dad calls me 6 times a day too.

NOAH

It’s not the same. You can ignore his calls. Try ignoring him when he shows up at 3 am, mom won't let him inside and he’s begging you to come out to the car and help him pop his hernia blister.

So again, do you think this dinner’s a good idea?

LINDSAY

I don't have a choice.

NOAH

Are you pregnant?

LINDSAY

No, I’m not pregnant. Does it have to be a crisis for us to get together? Can’t it be a good thing?

LINDSAY

Do you know if Dad is coming to dinner? He keeps saying he needs

to think about it. What is he thinking about?

NOAH

How should I know? I tried talking to him but he keeps switching the conversation back to his prostate. I can't hear about it anymore.

LINDSAY

We need to come up with a game plan.

NOAH

For what?

LINDSAY

To have a normal dinner.

NOAH

Then why did you invite our family

LINDSAY

If we could just team up maybe keep them distracted.

NOAH

You mean get them drunk enough

LINDSAY

It could work... I’m desperate. I’m losing it. Literally. My hair is shedding. Cliff is starting to notice
\

NOAH

That your going bald?

LINDSAY

No. That I’m freaking out about tomorrow.

NOAH

You should try these fish oil pills Dad has me on.

LINDSAY

Dad already sent me a case last week. Plus you owe me.

NOAH

I don’t owe you.

LINDSAY

Oh yes, you do.

NOAH.
For what?

LINDSAY

The thousand dollars I lent you last year when you swore the Giants were gonna win.

NOAH

You said that was a gift.

LINDSAY

A gift you can now repay me for.

NOAH

I’ll try but you know it's not gonna happen the way you want it to.

LINDSAY

Dad listens to you. Just don't start anything with him. Ok. Don't tease him. He hates when you do

that. It’s us against them remember.

NOAH

I can't handle your stress and mine. My app is coming out soon and I need to focus.

(SHERRI comes down the stairs)

SHERRI

Oh please. That app has been (hand air quotations) coming out for the last 2 years.

NOAH

You don't know what you’re talking about. If you’d just invest a little more money I wouldn't have to keep postponing.

SHERRI

You won’t even tell me what the app does.

NOAH

I don’t want anyone to steal my idea. It’s on lockdown until I can get a patent lawyer.

SHERRI

And who’s paying for that?

NOAH

Dad said he might

SHERRI

So he’s your partner now. Does he know what the app is? Because I

was the one who convinced him to invest in a fax machine. If you think he’s gonna be better than me go for it.

LINDSAY

Dad didn't want to buy a fax machine?

SHERRI

He wouldn't let me use it for the first month. He was worried it might give us cancer. You know he has cancer on his side of the family.

LINDSAY

Yeah, Mom, we know.

Sherri

And depression. That’s where you and NOAH get it from.

LINDSAY

I’m not depressed.

SHERRI

You always put on a little weight when you’re stressed.

NOAH

I thought she was pregnant?

LINDSAY

Anything else?

SHERRI

Where’s Clive?

LINDSAY

It’s Cliff and he’s at the hotel.

SHERRI
You left him at the hotel!

LINDSAY
The plan is that he’s gonna meet the 4 of us at dinner tomorrow.

SHERRI
The four of us?

LINDSAY
Yes. The four of us. I invited dad over here.

SHERRI
You invited your father here?? To my house? It’s not Yom Kippur.

LINDSAY
Do we need a High Holy Day to sit down and eat dinner as a family?

NOAH
Yes.

SHERRI
If your father wants to meet Cliff so badly he can take us all out to dinner.

LINDSAY
I thought we’d do better in a private setting. Don't you? You do remember my Graduation dinner right?

NOAH
But we got free cheesecake.

LINDSAY
That cause the Cheesecake Factory comped our bill if we would just leave.

SHERRI
We wouldn't have had such a problem if the manager hadn't been such an idiot.

LINDSAY
Regardless. I think it would be better if we had it here.

SHERRI
Oh Great. Having your father here…

NOAH
Don't look at me.

LINDSAY
Just promise you guys won't fight.

SHERRI
Why would I fight? What do we have to fight about any more?

LINDSAY
That's never seemed to stop you before.

(LINDSAY’s cell phone rings.)

LINDSAY
It’s Dad… Again. He keeps calling me.

(she ends the call)

SHERRI
Don't answer it. He always calls when there’s a problem.

LINDSAY
Cliff has had all his shots if anyone asks.

NOAH
Is he a dog?

LINDSAY
Just in case Dad asks.

(The house phone rings now)

SHERRI
Now he’s calling the house phone. Tell him if wants to come over here he better bring something decent.I’m not cooking for him.

LINDSAY
Mom. Where’s the phone? He’s just gonna keep on calling. Ma!

(SHERRI hands the phone to LINDSAY)

HAMMOND (VO)
HI, LINDSAY. Can you hear me?

LINDSAY
Yes. I can hear you.

HAMMOND (VO)
Is NOAH with you?

LINDSAY
Yeah

HAMMOND (VO)
Do you know if NOAH did something with my car keys?

LINDSAY
How would I know that?

HAMMOND (VO)
Alright. Shit. I can’t find them. Did you get in alright?

LINDSAY
Yes. The flight was fine.

HAMMOND (VO)
Where’s Cliff. Is he there at the house?

LINDSAY
He’s at the hotel.

HAMMOND (VO)
Did your mother meet him yet?

LINDSAY
No mom hasn't met him yet either.

HAMMOND (VO)
Is she on the phone. Can she hear me?

LINDSAY
No she can’t hear you.

HAMMOND (VO)
You didn't use the bathroom, did you? I just read an article about Laguardia urinals.

LINDSAY
No. I didn't use the bathroom at the airport. Besides, I don’t use Urinals.

HAMMOND (VO)
Swear to God. You’re not lying.

LINDSAY
No. I’m not. Why would I lie? Look, Are you coming over for dinner tomorrow or not?

HAMMOND (VO)
What time is it? Will your mother be there. You know I’m not feeling so great. Is Vicki coming?

LINDSAY
I’m only in town for a few days. It’s a family dinner.

HAMMOND (VO)
Why don't you come over and we can discuss it?

LINDSAY

I can't come over now. I have to get back to Cliff.

HAMMOND (VO)
Please. Come over. I have a bagel I could give you. I need help with my computer.

LINDSAY
I really don't have time to help you with your computer today.

HAMMOND (VO)
But you're smart. You worked for Apple.

LINDSAY
I worked at the Apple Store like 10 years ago, and you have a PC. Can you make dinner or not?

HAMMOND (VO)
You sound congested. Are you sick?

LINDSAY
No, I already told you I’m not sick.

HAMMOND (VO)
Look. Come over. I’ll give you some new supplements. I got. Just come over for an hour. Help me out. Come on.

LINDSAY
Okay. Okay. But just for an hour. Because I can't spend all day.

HAMMOND (VO)
Alright. Well if it’s more than an hour are you going to time me?

LINDSAY
No I’m not going to time you.

SHERRI
Tell him to bring a pizza

LINDSAY
She wants you to bring a pizza.

HAMMOND (VO)
What! Can’t she make something?

LINDSAY
He wants you to make something.

SHERRI
Why should I make him something? Tell him to pick up a pizza from DiNardos.

LINDSAY
SHe wants you to pick one up from DiNardos.

HAMMOND (VO)
Why can't she make one?

LINDSAY
Cause she doesn't want to make one?

HAMMOND (VO)
Why not. What is she doing?

LINDSAY
I don't know why?

HAMMOND (VO)
Listen. I’m not getting along with the owner of DiNardos at the moment. He’s not gonna want me in there.

LINDSAY
You got banned from DiNardos?

SHERRI
He got banned from DiNardos! How did he-

LINDSAY
You know what. Forget it. No, we’ll figure something out.

HAMMOND (VO)

But you're still coming over?

LINDSAY
I’m leaving now.

HAMMOND (VO)
Alright. Cause if your gonna be a few minutes. I’m gonna take a shower.

LINDSAY
I’m leaving now

HAMMOND (VO)
ALright, but if I’m in the shower I’ll leave the door open.

LINDSAY
You can’t wait to take a shower?

HAMMOND
What. Do you. What are you the shower police? Just come over.

LINDSAY
I’m going over to Dad’s.

NOAH AND SHERRI
Good Luck.

Scene 4

Friday evening. Lindsay enters HAMMOND's apartment. It's crowded with empty bottles and stacks of newspapers.

LINDSAY
Ok. Show me the problem. Ugh. What is, ugh that smell…. It smells like…. Is that? Is that rotting fish.

(LINDSAY walks over to the counter and picks up a bottle of fish oil)

HAMMOND
WHAT. NO...I don't smell anything. Maybe it's you. Check your shoes? Maybe you stepped in dog garbage?

LINDSAY
It's these. Ugh. You have to refrigerate them.

HAMMOND
WHAT. Are you kidding me? I just bought those.

LINDSAY
You still need to refrigerate them.

HAMMOND

They aren’t rotting. That's what they're supposed to smell like. Why? Do you think there’s something wrong with them? You know I wasn't feeling good this morning. Do you think I should call doctor Finkus? She might be able to fit me in....

LINDSAY

Why are you still seeing my old pediatrician?

HAMMOND

Why? It doesn't matter.

(HAMMOND smells the container)

There's nothing wrong with it. I trust her. She did a good job with you.

LINDSAY

You're fine Dad.

HAMMOND

Why are you so annoyed. Did you eat enough? I just pulled out half a power bar from the freezer.

(LINDSAY slips the power bar in her pocket)

HAMMOND

Here take this.

(HAMMOND pulls out a bottle of vitamins).

It’s got the blueberry extract. Take it with some warm water….

(He scrambles around his apartment and finds an old crushed up water bottle, half empty)

I’ve got a guy at Vitaworld, he’s very very smart.

LINDSAY

Why should I trust him?

HAMMOND

Because he’s always there. I can get him on the phone if you want to talk to him.

LINDSAY

I don’t want to talk to this guy. Besides. I don't need it. What does Blueberry extract even do?

HAMMOND

Sherri, you should take -- -I mean Lindsay. I just called you by your mother's name. I’m all over --. Just take it! You’ll be glad, my guy is smart. He knows his stuff.

Look I need to get this done! I got so much going on at the moment. My throat hurts, I’ve been on the phone all morning with Grandma’s doctor. He didn't even want to talk about my blister/

LINDSAY

/Okay.God. I hear you. I’ll take the vitamin and then you can show me what’s wrong with your computer.

You're coming over for dinner tomorrow. Right?

HAMMOND

Right. Whatever you want. We can talk about it when you fix the computer.

(LINDSAY and HAMMOND sit down in front of the computer)

(A projected computer screen shows a mess of Icons, obscurely labeled and outdated)

LINDSAY

I don't see the problem. What are you trying to do?

HAMMOND
Listen. Something happened with my icons. Somebody moved my ICONS, either AOL or the other one. It worked before, I just clicked on it and it appeared. I had a very smart guy set it up. He’s from Apple.

LINDSAY
Dad, this is a Gateway PC.

HAMMOND
I asked him if he knew you but I don’t have any recent photos. You never give me any photos of you. I forget what you look like. We don’t even have any together. You know I might know where my camera is.

LINDSAY
Let's just take care of one thing at a time. What did this guy do?

HAMMOND
He set it up just how I like it.

LINDSAY
All you are doing is clicking a blank folder. This computer is so slow you really need to get a new one.

HAMMOND
No. It's a Supercomputer. He’s a very smart guy, my guy. The brains are very good, inside it's a supercomputer. It’s got “Anti Virus” and “Autocorrect”. I need you to. This guy set it up perfectly … I need to get photos. I don’t want to lose them. But don't look at them. Just open them.

LINDSAY
Why don't you ask this guy then? I really don’t know how to help you.

HAMMOND
No. Come on. You’re smart. You’re a smart girl. You can figure it out… He isn't answering my calls. He’s got another job. Just get my pictures out. But don't look at them. Sherri-Lindsay. Oh, Jesus. Please come on.

LINDSAY
Can't this wait? It really doesn't seem urgent. I have to get back to Cliff, he’s been at the hotel all day.

HAMMOND
Sherri. Come On…..

HAMMOND
Look. What do you want from me. I’ve had a ROTTEN... A ROTTEN time. You’ve screwed up my whole day. I haven't even taken a shower yet. I gotta go see Dr. Finkus, you insulted my fish oil pills. Will you just. Will you just do it.

LINDSAY
Dad! Come over here and pay attention! That way you’ll know how to do it yourself.

HAMMOND
Just don't change anything.

LINDSAY
First, why are all these files clustered in the corner?

(LINDSAY opens an audio file and Sympathy For The Devil by The Rolling Stones starts playing)

HAMMOND
Who gave you that? Did AOL give you that? You know I saw them in concert. Third Row Center at Madison Square Garden. It was my first big show. I bought up a bunch of tickets. Sold them all on the street. NO one had better tickets than me.

LINDSAY
I know dad.

HAMMOND
I took you to see them. What other 6 years old gets to see The Rolling Stones. Do you remember that?

LINDSAY
No…Dad. Is this the file?

(Suddenly all his photos appear, images of a woman dancing topless in the chair Lindsay's sitting in)

HAMMOND
Awwww. Geez. I told you not to look.

LINDSAY
Is that Dee Dee? I thought you guys broke up. Why is she naked in this chair? Why would you need these photos? You made me come over to find these Photos! OH God. What is wrong with you?

HAMMOND
Just relax. Relax. It's not a big deal. You're the one that opened them. Here take a Xanax. Calm Down.

LINDSAY

I don’t need a Xanax Dad. I can't do this anymore. I have to go back to the hotel

HAMMOND
Wait. Wait. Wait. What did you click. How do I. What button is this?

LINDSAY
Dad. I’m leaving I can’t keep doing this with you. Every time it’s the same thing. I just get sucked into your crazy. Can’t you just be a dad for 5 freaking minutes?!

HAMMOND
Wait! How do I find the rest of them? Did you move something?

LINDSAY
This is my weekend and I can’t spend anymore time helping you find your porn collection.

HAMMOND
You shouldn't drive like this. Take a Xanax, you’ll calm down and I’ll see you tomorrow at dinner. And don’t tell your mother.

(Lindsay takes the Xanax)

LINDSAY
Fine! Then don't forget the pizza.

SCENE 5

Friday night. Back at the hotel, Lindsay walks into the hotel room and collapses on to the bed.

LINDSAY
Cliff. Cliff. Are you still here?

CLIFF
Hang on. I’m just washing my hands…

CLIFF
Are you Okay? You look tired. How did things go?

LINDSAY
Things went really really well.

CLIFF

Did your family give you a hard time?

LINDSAY
Noo. Nooo. I mean it's a little stressful.

CLIFF
It’s always stressful.

LINDSAY
It wasn't so bad when I first got here. How long has it been?

CLIFF
Less than day

LINDSAY
Oh. That's terrifying.

CLIFF
What have you told them so far?

LINDSAY
Nothing. I want to wait until dinner. That way we only have to do it onced.

CLIFF
Are you okay? You seem weirdly calm.

LINDSAY
My dad gave me some pills to help.

CLIFF
What pills?

LINDSAY
It’s fine.

CLIFF

What did you take?

LINDSAY

Blueberry extract, Fish oil, Xanax.

CLIFF

Xanax?

LINDSAY

Just so I could drive.

CLIFF

You drove on Xanax.

LINDSAY

CLiff. Relax. I worked it all out. My dad’s coming to dinner.

CLIFF

And we're happy about this?

LINDSAY

My mom promised not to fight. NOAH and I have a gameplan. It’s gonna be perfect. Their gonna accept you like the son they wish they had and then bada bing bada boom we’ll tell them were engaged. Yakkita Yakkita we open the champagne and then we can all be happy.

CLIFF

Even if it doesn't go just like that we can still be happy.

LINDSAY

We can't be happy if they don't like you. I’ll never hear the end of it. Every phone call, every

text message every family event will turn into a fight about you.

CLIFF

Lindsay all families fight.

LINDSAY

Not like mine

CLIFF

Just like yours. You're Not special. I mean that in the best possible way.

LINDSAY

You only think that because your family is normal. They live in Cleveland, their nice and they never fight in front of me. Life has not prepared you for my family. I'm scared that when you see what they're like you’re gonna leave.

CLIFF

In not going anywhere. In a few months, we’ll splice normal and crazy together and live blissfully in the middle.

LINDSAY

Swear on your Eagle Scout’s honor.

CLIFF

Okay. I swear. Eagle Scout’s honor.

LINDSAY

Maybe if things go really well tomorrow we can go engagement ring shopping after dinner. Wouldn't that be great?

CLIFF

Let’s not obsess about the ring. Let’s just focus on getting through this weekend. Why don't we get you some food and we’ll take it easy tonight?

LINDSAY
Oh, I have half a power bar my from my Dad’s freezer!

CLIFF
I was thinking something a little more filling. Why don't you go wash your face and we’ll head out.

LINDSAY
Okay. But not pizza.

(Lindsay walks into the bathroom and shuts the door. CLIFF takes out his phone, dials)

CLIFF
Hi Sherri. It’s Cliff. Can we talk?

Scene 6

Saturday evening at 35 Hankly Circle. Lindsay and NOAH are preparing the table, moving old bottles of pills and newspapers stacked high. Sherri is in the kitchen preparing an appetizer. Cliff is outside with Nora.

SHERRI
All you had to do was throw the ball around with Nora for 5 minutes and she would’ve calmed

down. Look how good Cliff is doing with her.

NOAH

I was going to do it.

SHERRI

When? It’s 4:30 in the afternoon. When were you going to do it?

NOAH

I just got up.

SHERRI

So what was your excuse yesterday?

NOAH

Mom why are you stressing everyone out right now. You know it’s not too late to cancel.

SHERRI

We’re not canceling. I just started making the appetizers. You know how expensive lox is plus I am not eating all these carbs by myself.

LINDSAY

I told you that you didn't need to cook. Dad is picking up a pizza.

SHERRI

You never know. He once came home with *sausage* on the pizza. I mean hello. I’ve only been kosher since we were married!

LINDSAY

There won't be sausage on the pizza.

NOAH

There might be.

LINDSAY

You’re NOT helping.

SHERRI

Do you eat sausage when you're with Cliff?

NOAH

MOM. Do you know what you’re asking?

SHERRI

What? I’m just asking a question.

NOAH

You just asked Lindsay if she goes down to BJ TOWN.

SHERRI

What no I didn't.. That’s disgusting. I just wanted to know if still keeps kosher.

LINDSAY

Why don’t we just stop talking about Cliff’s Sausage.

SHERRI

What time did you say your father was going to be here.

NOAH & LINDSAY

5!

NOAH

How many times do we have to say it.

SHERRI

There’s no need to yell at me. I’m just asking.

NOAH

I’m not yelling.

SHERRI

It looks like Nora is already tiring Cliff out. Does he work out? It doesn't look like he has a lot of muscle on him.

LINDSAY

Yes. He works out. What’s wrong with him?

SHERRI

I didn’t say anything was wrong with him. I just always pictured you with someone a little more masculine.

LINDSAY

Cliff. He’s plenty masculine. You should see his back hair.

SHERRI

I only meant I thought you liked stronger guys.

LINDSAY

Cliff actually just got a promotion.

NOAH

Oh really. How much money is he making now?

LINDSAY

He just got offered 108 after taxes.

SHERRI

That’s not bad.

NOAH

Dude. Do you think he’d want to invest in my app?

SHERRI

Oh. That’s an idea. He’s good with computers right? It could be a family project.

LINDSAY

Well, he’s an engineer but work has been super busy lately.

SHERRI

I’m sure he’d make the effort. NOAH just ask him.

NOAH

Ma. We’ll see.

SHERRI

This is exactly why nothings happening with the app. I’m never gonna get my money back unless you start putting in some effort.

SHERRI

Cliff! Cliff, bring Nora. Come inside!Come inside it’s gettin’ dark.

NOAH

MOM. Stop. I don’t want to do it right now.

SHERRI

How do you think your father and I built up a successful business. I can tell you it wasnt from sleeping till 4:30 everyday

NOAH

It’s my app. I’ll ask him if I wanna ask him.

SHERRI

Fine. What do I know I‘ll just go back to cooking dinner for everyone.

NOAH

Are you sure you don’t want to call this off? Mom is already being way too much. Dad’s only gonna make it worse.

LINDSAY

It’s just dinner.

SHERRI

Can someone hand me a tomato, please?

NOAH

Do you think we’ll even be into the first glass of wine before Dad mentions his prostate?

LINDSAY

I bet mom will love that.

SHERRI

Hello?

LINDSAY

He calls me about it at least once a week. I ask my friends how much

they know about their father's anus. Surprisingly it's not a popular subject.

NOAH

Have you seen the video of his colonoscopy yet?

SHERRI

Is.. Everyone..Can anyone Fucking HEAR ME!

SHERRI

Just don't answer me right! What did I just ask you for?

LINDSAY

A tomato?

SHERRI

Yes

LINDSAY

I'm Sorry. I didn't hear you. NOAH and I were talking.

NOAH

Mom. I love you. Calm down. Please. Jesus Christ

LINDSAY

I know you're worried about Dad

SHERRI

I'm not worried about Dad…I just need a tomato. Do you want to eat or not.

(NOAH picks up a tomato and hands it to SHERRI)

SHERRI

This one’s too soft. DO you even know what good tomato feels like?

(LINDSAY brings the whole fruit bowl over to SHERRI)

I only needed one. CLiff. Honey. Can you a pick out a tomato for me.

CLIFF

Sure. This one seems good.

SHERRI

Mazel. What a perfect tomato. You wanna wash your hands and come help me.

(Cliff walks over and washes his hands)

So is Cliff short for anything?

CLIFF

Well actually my name is Christopher but my family has always called me Cliff.

SHERRI

CHRISTOPHER! I’m assuming there are no Jews in your family.

CLIFF

No but Lindsay has been teaching me all about it. What did we have the other day? Aruggalah

LINDSAY

Rugelach.

SHERRI

OOh. Did you like it. Lindsay, you should have told me he liked it. I could have had it ready for him. So should I call you Christopher?

CLIFF

Whatever feels comfortable to you.

SHERRI

Well, Christopher. Lindsay just told me you got a promotion. Are they making you work more hours now? What's your schedule look like. You know you have to make sure you have a balance.

HAMMOND worked constantly throughout our marriage. I made every clarinet recital Lindsay ever had. Do you know how many HAMMOND made?

CLIFF

How many?

SHERRI

Zero! All I'm saying is make sure to make time for my shayna punim. She was the cutest baby. You should have seen her. You know I sent her picture into the Ford modeling agency. Everyone would stop me and say how gorgeous she was.

CLIFF

She's still gorgeous.

NOAH

Awwwwww. Look at that face.

(The doorbell rings. Nora begins to bark. The doorbell rings again)

SHERRI

Does he think we’re deaf? He’s getting Nora all riled up.

LINDSAY

I’ll get it.

(LINDSAY gets up to get the door. HAMMOND enters on his phone)

HAMMOND

No. Absolutely not. It's gotta to be right over the yard line. Lenny. What are you telling me this for now. No… Absolutely not. Lenny. We’ve known each other a long time. No Fuck You!

LINDSAY

Dad?

HAMMOND

What? What is it? I’m on the phone…

Yes. Lenny. Hang on my daughters here. Hold on….

LINDSAY

Dad you made it and you're in time. Wait. Where’s the Pizza?

HAMMOND

Hang on Lenny. Shit. You’re not gonna believe this. I forgot it.

LINDSAY

That was your one job.

HAMMOND

I’m sure you can work something out with your mother. I brought wine.

LINDSAY

But we brought wine.

HAMMOND

Just give me a minute.

Lenny. How much are the Giants Tickets? That's crazy… I’m not paying that. The way their playing this season. They're out of their mind.

(HAMMOND walks off to the living room. We hear the sound of the Giant’s game)

LINDSAY

Cliff. Cliff. Can you come in here for a sec?

CLIFF

What’s up?

LINDSAY

Can you just. Can you watch the game with my dad?

CLIFF

But your mom wants me to help her

LINDSAY

Just let me introduce you. Just hang out with him for a bit. I’ll be right back.

CLIFF

Alright.

LINDSAY

Dad. Dad. I want you to meet CLiff.

HAMMOND

Hi. Hi It's nice to meet you. Lindsay, I'm on the phone with Grandma.

LINDSAY

What happened to Lenny?

(LINDSAY walks back to the kitchen)

HAMMOND

Yeah. Ma.. Ma. Hang on a second. I'm with Lindsay's boyfriend.

HAMMOND

Her BOYFRIEND…Hang On. She wants to say hello.

CLIFF

Um.

HAMMOND

Just say hello. Yeah.. Ma I'm putting him on.

(CLIFF takes the phone)

CLIFF

Hello. Is this Lindsay's grandma. Yes, I am dating your granddaughter. Lindsay. I'm dating Lindsay. Um. No. I'm Catholic.. . CATHOLIC.

CLIFF

Ugh. I don't think she can hear me very well.

HAMMOND

She's fine. Keep talking.

CLIFF
We haven't talked about converting yet. No I'm not circumcised. Ugh Boca seems a little far for me to go for my own Briss. Do you want to speak to HAMMOND?

HAMMOND
Ma. Ma. I'll have to call you back. The Giants are on the 40-yard line. I'll call you. SON OF A BITCH. Manning threw another interception. Not you Ma. Let me call you back. Alright. Love you.

Can you believe that CLiff? Who's your team? Are you into the Bears.

Fuck. Their line sucks. Eli has no protection. He's rushing. He's getting hit on every single play.

Who's your team? Please tell me you're not a Dallas fan.
The Giants used to be really hot but their screwing up big time at the moment. I knew I shouldn't have bet money on them this morning. I had this feeling.Leave it to me to pick the one game they're fucking up.

I don't believe it. Jesus. Are you seeing this

CLIFF
Manning!

HAMMOND
Do you know what they're paying him? 26 Million. Can you believe it and he throws like that.

CLIFF
Yeah! I know.

HAMMOND

Do you ever go to games?

CLIFF
I went to my first Bear’s game this year.

HAMMOND
Oh yeah. I used to go all the time myself. You know when I was a kid I could never afford to see them. But I was clever back then. I’d wait around. You’d always get someone who’d leave half way through. I’d convince them to give me their ticket. That’s pretty smart right.

CLIFF
Very Smart. You sound like Lindsay.

HAMMOND
You mean Lindsay sounds like me. She’s good too you know. Last time we went to a Giants game it was freezing. My teeth were chattering. So you know what Lindsay does. She talks her way into a skybox. She’s like Dad come with me. She convinces them were part of this wedding. I’ve never met these people in my life. You should of seen the spread. The chicken wings were to die for. It was amazing.

CLIFF
She doesn't do that anymore

HAMMOND
Why not? There's nothing wrong with it. I taught her everything she knows.

CLIFF
Have you heard of Situational Ethics?

HAMMOND
The giants franchise is worth 3.3 billion dollars. What's a few chicken wings?!

(Lights out on HAMMOND and CLIFF. Lights up on LINDSAY and NOAH in the kitchen)

LINDSAY

NOAH. NOAH.

NOAH

What?

LINDSAY
Dad forgot the pizza.

NOAH

I told you

LINDSAY

Mom's gonna to have another meltdown. Can you order one?

NOAH
My income isn't liquid right now.

LINDSAY
I'll pay for it. Just order it before mom figures it out.

NOAH

She's gonna figure it out. It's Mom.

(LINDSAY gives her credit card to NOAH, HAMMOND, CLIFF and SHERRI enters the kitchen)

HAMMOND
What’s for dinner?

SHERRI
What do you mean what’s for dinner.

LINDSAY
Don't freak out.

SHERRI
What did he do?

NOAH
He forgot the pizza

SHERRI
I knew it. I said it, didn't I say it, NOAH?

NOAH
You said it.

HAMMOND
You’re already making appetizers. Could you just … whip up a dinner for 4?

SHERRI
5! What about Christopher?

HAMMOND
Who’s Christopher?

CLIFF
You know, I’m not that hungry.

SHERRI
Your daughter’s boyfriend

LINDSAY
Please mom

SHERRI

Why should I? He’s the one who screwed up. I’m done cleaning up his mistakes...

LINDSAY

Do it for us. We're a family remember? Right NOAH?

NOAH

Yeah…

We’re a family.

SHERRI

Kitchens closed. Order the pizza and you better believe he’s paying for it.

HAMMOND

Didn’t I give you enough money in the divorce to cover a pizza?

SHERRI

Like hell you did.

HAMMOND (To NOAH)

We could have hired a team of engineers for your app with all the money she wasted on lawyers.

SHERRI

You’ve got some nerve. You still haven't given him the money you promised for his bar mitzvah.

(addressing NOAH)

Like he was ever gonna really give it to you …

LINDSAY

I’ll pay for the pizza. Let’s all just sit down and relax.

CLIFF

Hey. I'll just order it on my phone. Extra large pizza. Two Salads. DiNardos right?

HAMMOND, NOAH, SHERRI and LINDSAY
Yeah.

HAMMOND
Don't give them my information

(NOAH sits at the head of the table)

HAMMOND
That's where I'm sitting.

NOAH
It's MY SEAT.

HAMMOND
NOAH… Come on. Get up. You know that's where you sit.

NOAH
NO! I am prepared to lose an arm for this seat.

(HAMMOND starts to pull NOAH in the chair away from the table)

NOAH
Dad you're gonna scratch the floor

SHERRI
HAMMOND don't you dare.

NOAH
It's my seat

HAMMOND
I always sit here.

NOAH
Not anymore.

SHERRI
Actually, it's my seat. I paid for it.

HAMMOND

We paid for it.

SHERRI
Do you want me to get out the divorce agreement?

LINDSAY
Can we just burn the chair?

HAMMOND
If I’m not sitting in this chair I’m not eating dinner.

LINDSAY
NOAH. Please. You promised.

(NOAH gets up from the chair. HAMMOND sits down)

NOAH
Fine. Whatever Butthole.

HAMMOND
You’re gonna talk to me like that?

SHERRI
What kind of language is that!

NOAH
Sorry ma. So are we planning to eat tonight? I mean I wasn't expecting to wait.

SHERRI
If your father had remembered the pizza we would be eating already.

LINDSAY
Mom, why don’t we get started on the lox?

HAMMOND
What do you want from me? Grandma is driving me crazy and then Lindsay just goes and springs dinner on me out of nowhere.

SHERRI
We’re drinking, right?

EVERYONE
Yes.

HAMMOND
Which wine are we getting?

SHERRI
The one Lindsay and Christopher brought from Chicago.

HAMMOND
Oh no. Let's get something different.

LINDSAY
Why? Greg recommended this specifically for you.

CLIff
Who’s Greg?

LINDSAY
I told you about him.

HAMMOND
Oh God. Please.

SHERRI
I already opened it.

HAMMOND
Oh Fuck no!

HAMMOND
Oh. No. No. Please. I’ll throw up.

HAMMOND
I’ve seen this wine. It gives me the worst indigestion. I’m getting heartburn just looking at it.

SHERRI
Are you out of your mind. This is 13 dollars. I happen to love it.

Lindsay said it was a good buy.
Don't you love it.

HAMMOND
Go on. I love it.

NOAH
We love it.

HAMMOND
It tastes medicinal.

SHERRI
That just means it’s good for you!

NOAH
I’m always up for being healthy

(NOAH downs half his glass)

LINDSAY
You know what. We haven't toasted yet. Why don’t we toast to Family?

NOAH
And maybe getting through one meal without a fight.

SHERRI
Yeah right.

HAMMOND
We could do it.

NOAH
Remains to be seen.

HAMMOND
We can make it through dinner! Come on. You're being ridiculous.

LINDSAY
I don't want to fight.

HAMMOND
We won't.

NOAH
we will.

LINDSAY
You’re not helping

SHERRI
When has NOAH helped with anything?

HAMMOND
There won't be any more arguments.

NOAH
There’s always another argument. It’ll be something like who paid for my braces?

SHERRI
Braces. Did you have braces NOAH?

LINDSAY
Of course, he had braces.

SHERRI
Did you have braces? I don't think so.

LINDSAY
Yes he did.

SHERRI
No he didn't. Did you have braces NOAH?

HAMMOND
No.

SHERRI
That’s what I’m saying.

CLIFF
I had braces.

NOAH
Look at this perfect smile. Think anything this perfect could come from our genes.

SHERRI
Really? Do you remember that HAMMOND?

HAMMOND
Nope.

LINDSAY
To not fighting.

NOAH
This Pizza is taking forever.

(NOAH refills his glass of wine)

CLIFF
The app says its on its way.

HAMMOND
You’re good at computers right?

CLIFF
According to my degree.

SHERRI
Could you help me with my iWatch? It’s not counting my steps.

CLIFF
Um.. I’m not sure. Let me take a look at it.

(SHERRI takes off her Apple Watch and hands it to CLIFF)

HAMMOND
I have a guy but he’s out of town right now and I really need to watch a video on Aol and I can't…. It won't click right. But I’ve got a good mouse. Can I have him call you?

CLIFF
What's the video you're trying to watch? Maybe I could find it online?

HAMMOND
I don't want to tell you.

CLIFF
Maybe before we go to the airport we could stop by

LINDSAY
Dad! Stop with the AOL videos.

SHERI
Lindsay says your making good money Cliff?

HAMMOND
NOAH maybe you could go back to school and be an engineer?

SHERRI
Yeah right. He'd have to finish college first. Do you know how much money I paid?

HAMMOND
How much we paid?

(NOAH takes a pill from his pocket and swallows it)

SHERRI
What was that? Are you taking drugs? Are you taking drugs in my house?

NOAH
It's just a Xanax.

SHERRI
Where did you get a Xanax?

NOAH
Dad gave it to me.

HAMMOND
Oh Great. I told you not to drink when you take it.

SHERRI
Why do you need a Xanax? Why does your son need a Xanax, HAMMOND?

LINDSAY
Lets all just calm down

SHERRI
Do you need to go rehab?

LINDSAY
He doesn't need rehab. In fact I think I might need another Xanax in a minute.

SHERRI
Don't you start.

CLIFF
Sherri I think I fixed the problem.

SHERRI
Oh. My God. Look how helpful you are.

SHERRI
Lindsay you did a good job with this one. Vicki is never this helpful.

HAMMOND
Vicki is wonderful.

NOAH
You only like her because she listens to you.

HAMMOND
Other people listen to me. I like Vicki because she cried on my shoulder for an hour. Cliff would never cry on my shoulder. Right Cliff?

(Everyone looks at CLIFF)

LINDSAY
I think if Cliff cried on your shoulder we wouldn't be dating.

HAMMOND
She came over in the middle of the night, told me her mother was a drug addict, she never knew her father, her life was empty before she met NOAH. You were everything to her.

NOAH
Dad.

HAMMOND
You were the night's sky, the night before. She was missing you, she cried. My shirt was wet with her tears.

LINDSAY
Are the two of you still together?

SHERRI
Oh God I hope not.

HAMMOND
She sat on my couch that night and quivered.

LINDSAY
She QUIVERED?

SHERRI
I haven't heard that word in years.

LINDSAY
Dad. I don't think that's the word you're looking for.

HAMMOND
Cliff, you know what I'm saying. When a woman is shaking with wild emotions.

(The doorbell rings)

CLIFF
Pizza!

NOAH
The Xanax is kicking in.

Scene 8

Later Saturday night. The Family is seated around the table.

LINDSAY
DiNardo’s is just as good as I remember it.

HAMMOND
Eh.I like their thin crust better. Maybe next time you get the thin crust Cliff.

NOAH
It’s still good.

CLIFF
Sherri, I think it might be time for Champagne.

HAMMOND
Why do we need champagne? You know I’m already feeling indigestion (Burp). Between the extra crust and that awful wine. Sherri. I need something. Do you still have those Papaya pills I left here?

Maybe it was the lox you made.

SHERRI
Don't look at me. It wasn't my food that made you sick.

(SHERRI gets up from the table to grab the pills)

NOAH
You know what Ma. I’ll take some of those pills too.

LINDSAY (to NOAH)
Are you okay?

SHERRI
You've had enough pills. Go sit on the toilet for a little bit if you really feel that sick.

NOAH
No. Are you serious. Give me some papaya pills.

LINDSAY
Stop drinking if you're feeling ill.

HAMMOND
Sherri What are you doing? I'm dying over here. I need the papaya pills.

SHERRI
HAMMOND. I'm coming. Between the two of you I've had enough. Cliff are you sure you really want to marry into this family.

LINDSAY
MOM. How do you know that?

SHERRI
Oh Shit. Oh Cliff. I"m sorry. I just go so distracted. Oh GOD.

HAMMOND
What do you mean Married? Sherri what do you know that I don't know.

SHERRI
Don't ask me anything.

LINDSAY
CLiff. What is going on?

CLIFF

I couldn't find a ring that expresses how much I love you and it felt wrong to buy something that wasn't meaningful to you. So I called your Mom and she offered me your grandmother's ring.

(CLIFF kneels down)

But last night I realized that there was something missing. Look at the inscription

LINDSAY
Eagle Scout’s Honor.

CLIFF
Now it’s official

(They Kiss)

LINDSAY
Mom I can’t believe you gave up Grandma’s ring.

HAMMOND
You know what, what’s a little more heartburn. Let’s get that champagne! My little bumblebee. I remember when you were a baby. I’m gonna have to see my podiatrist if I’m gonna walk you down the aisle.

NOAH
Oh.. I thought you were pregnant.

SHERRI
Don't be an idiot. She’s not pregnant.

HAMMOND
You shouldn't drink if you're pregnant, Lindsay.

LINDSAY
I’m not pregnant! I’m Engaged.

NOAH

Mom. What about me? You said I could have grandmas ring.

SHERRI
I’m not giving Vicky my ring.

HAMMOND
You know Steve past I95 sells rings? I could get you a good deal.

NOAH
I don’t want some shady guy’s weird rings.

HAMMOND
Steve’s not shady. You met him.

NOAH
When?

HAMMOND
1993.

NOAH
Dad, I was 5.

SHERRI
You can have my old engagement ring instead.

NOAH
The divorce ring?

SHERRI
Oh, don’t call it that.

NOAH
But that’s what you call it. So we all act like a normal happy family for Lindsay and boyfriend number 5 even though I’m the one who didn't leave and you shit all over me. Dad. I have reminders in my reminders to remind you for every bullshit doctors appointment.

And Mom all you do is make me feel like shit. When I’ve been the one

taking care of you. You lock me out of my own house and you won't even give me just a little more money to finish my app.

SHERRI
I'm done throwing money away on nothing.

NOAH
You think my app is nothing. Is that what you all think? Alright, you wanna know what a loser I am.

(NOAH pulls out his phone)

Congratulate the second highest indie beta launch in the last three years.

(Everyone takes out their phone except LINDSAY)

CLIFF
Is this you? We Won't Fight an interactive experience that finally settles the score. Upload your personal fights and let the world decide who won.

(CLIFF clicks on the latest uploaded argument)

[Audio plays]

SHERRI
Did you have braces NOAH?

LINDSAY
Of course, he had braces.

HAMMOND
Did you have braces? I don't think so.

SHERRI
Is that us? Did you record us?

HAMMOND
I don't sound like that.

(Cliff clicks on another file and listens)

CLIFF
These files. Lindsay. Did you record us?

LINDSAY
He just needed more people to contribute to the app. I just wanted to help my brother.

CLIFF
How long have you been recording me?

LINDSAY
Just a few weeks. I swear. It was just so he could have enough to launch his app. It’s all anonymous.

CLIFF
I don't even know what to say. This whole time you acted like you couldn’t trust me.

LINDSAY
I’m sorry. I’m sorry. Please I don't want to fight. We just made things official. It was stupid I’m sorry.

CLIFF
I don't even know what to say. I need a walk.

(CLIFF leaves)

SHERRI
Take Nora if your going out.

HAMMOND
NOAH. SHow me on my phone. People pay to listen to me.

SHERRI
Who wins these fights? Who's winning right now?

NOAH

Actually Ma. You win most of the time.

LINDSAY
Crazy. I’m just as crazy as you guys. This whole time. Trying to stop everyone from fighting. To have something normal, something not apocalyptic. Why did I think I was any better.

HAMMOND
We’re normal.

SHERRI
I don't know why you’re getting so upset.

(LINDSAY rushes outside)

LINDSAY
I thought you were going for a walk.

CLIFF
I just needed to think.

LINDSAY
I’m so sorry I hid this from you.

CLIFF
If you had just told me.

LINDSAY
I suck at being a person. I’m carrying around all this baggage from my family and that’s not on you. I don't know how to be normal.

CLIFF
I’m not normal. There's no such thing. I’ve seen the worst your family can do and I’m still here. But you can't lie to me. If we're gonna have something real it’s not gonna be perfect.

LINDSAY
Okay.

(They embrace)

I think I might need some help with that.

CLIFF
There’s always therapy. Let's go pop that champagne.

(They walk back into the kitchen. Nora is barking.)

LINDSAY
Why is the dog barking?

SHERRI
The can is on top of the shelf to the left. THE LEFT.

NOAH
Dad! Are you serious. You used to live here. It’s right over there.

(NOAH opens the cabinet for HAMMOND. HAMMOND takes out a can of dog food and moves it to the electric opener)

HAMMOND
She moved everything around. How was I supposed to know.

SHERRI
I didn't move anything around.

(HAMMOND slices his hand on the can opener. Blood begins pouring out of his cut. A fountain of red liquid puddling to the floor.)

HAMMOND
Oh Jesus. Oh you gotta be kidding me…. Son of a bitch. . Oh My GOD. Sherri. Sherri my hand.

SHERRI
HAMMONDs…. You’re getting blood all over my granite counter. The sink -- put your hand in the sink.

(NORA continues barking)

HAMMOND
What should I? What should I do? I knew something bad was gonna happen. I knew it. I felt it. I should of said something. Sherri, you gotta drive me to the hospital

SHERRI
ME? I’m not getting blood all over my Lexus.

HAMMOND
I’m dying.

SHERRI
You aren't dying.

NOAH
Vicki knew a guy who actually got a mucus infection in his hand.

SHERRI
A what. That doesn't make any sense

HAMMOND
OH jesus. I don't need a Mucus infection

SHERRI
YOU CAN'T GET A MUCUS INFECTION FROM A HAND CUT. YOUR HAND DOESN'T HAVE MUCUS.

CLIFF
What’s happening?

SHERRI
FINE. I’ll pull the car up. But you are sitting on a towel.

HAMMOND
OH GOD. I need to call DR. Finkus.

(HAMMOND screams into his phone)

Call Dr. Finkus.

DR. Finkus I have mucus coming out of my hand.

LINDSAY
But I thought we were gonna celebrate.

HAMMOND (VO)
I’m leaking all over.

SHERRI
You better not be or so help me.

(They run off stage)

NOAH. NOAH. Bring more paper towels!

NOAH
Welcome to the family

(NOAH runs off stage)

LINDSAY
That went well.

THE END